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Marketing

12 research documents · each with plain-language key takeaways

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Category Design for Print-Flow-360: Should We Create a Category, or Own a Segment?

Source: readme/research/marketing/CATEGORY_DESIGN_AND_NARRATIVE_2026-06-16.md

IN SHORT — KEY TAKEAWAYS

This document answers one question: how should Print-Flow-360 position itself so the right customers choose it over bigger competitors? It explains two different strategies and picks the one that makes sense for an early-stage business — then gives you the exact words and story to use. This matters because if you talk to the wrong customers or use the wrong message, marketing money and effort goes to waste.

The main parts explained simply:

- **Category Design vs. Owning a Segment** — "Category design" means convincing the world a brand-new type of product exists (think inventing the iPhone category). "Owning a segment" means being the best known option for one specific group inside a category that already exists. The document says category design costs $100M+ and takes years — not realistic for a startup. Owning a segment is the smarter, cheaper play.
- **Why Print-Flow-360 should own a segment, not create a category** — "Web-to-print" is already a known term that shop owners search for. The big players (like OnPrintShop and DesignNBuy) all target large companies and IT teams. Small, non-technical, independent print shops are being ignored. That gap is the segment Print-Flow-360 should own and dominate.
- **Naming an Enemy** — Good marketing names what the customer is frustrated by — not a competitor, but the situation. Here the "enemy" is the old belief that going online means hiring a developer or paying an agency $10–30k. Naming that frustration out loud makes customers feel understood.
- **Old Way vs. New Way** — A simple before-and-after story: the old way = expensive developers, confusing enterprise software, or surrendering to Vistaprint. The new way = a shop owner sets up their own online store themselves, in an afternoon, without any technical help.
- **The Promised Land** — The vision of what life looks like after the customer uses the product: customers design and order online at midnight, the shop owner wakes up to print-ready jobs, and local shops compete with big giants on their own terms.
- **Narrative Arc (the story structure)** — Five steps: (1) something has changed — customers now expect to order online; (2) the risk of doing nothing — Vistaprint takes your customers; (3) the false options — agency, enterprise software, or give up; (4) the better future — your own branded storefront, no code needed; (5) Print-Flow-360 as the bridge that gets you there.
- **Concrete tactics** — Rewrite the homepage to lead with the enemy and the promised land, not features. Publish one sharp essay explaining who the product is for and why existing options fail small shops. Lead with one simple, specific use case (like "your own business-card store, live today") rather than listing everything.
- **Mistakes to avoid** — Don't invent a confusing new category name. Don't attack competitors by name. Don't chase big trade printers and enterprise customers — that destroys the one thing that makes Print-Flow-360 special.

What to do with this: Pick the segment ("web-to-print for non-technical, owner-run print shops") and say it clearly, everywhere — homepage, sales calls, essays, onboarding. Make every screen in the

> product match that promise: if a store owner sees a technical error or a confusing setting, the story falls apart immediately.

TL;DR: Don't try to invent a brand-new market category from scratch — that's a $100M, 6-to-10-year game that kills early-stage startups. Instead, run a *category-design-lite* play: **niche down hard inside the existing, well-understood "web-to-print" category and own the segment "web-to-print for non-technical, independent print shops."** Use the full narrative toolkit (named enemy, old-way-vs-new-way, promised land) to make that ownership *feel* like a category, without taking on the cost and risk of educating a market that doesn't yet know it has a problem.

> **Why this matters for Print-Flow-360.** Our buyer — a non-technical local print shop owner — is the single most important fact in our entire go-to-market. These owners already *know* they need to "sell online," and they already *know* the category is called "web-to-print." We do not need to teach them a new word. We need to teach them that the existing options were built for IT departments and trade printers, and that there's finally one built for *them*. That's a positioning fight we can win this quarter, not a category-creation war that needs a war chest we don't have.

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1. The core concepts, taught plainly

A product is the thing you build. **A category** is the *mental shelf* a buyer puts it on before they even compare features. When a shop owner thinks "I need web-to-print software," "web-to-print" is the shelf, and they'll reach for whatever's on it. Positioning is the work of deciding *which shelf you want to be on* and *why you're the obvious pick on that shelf*.

There are two strategic schools here, and they pull in opposite directions:

School A — Category Design (Play Bigger)

The book *Play Bigger* (Ramadan, Peterson, Lochhead, Maney) argues that the biggest winners don't win existing markets — they **design new ones** and then dominate them. Their data point is the headline: the category *king* captures roughly **76% of the total market value**, leaving everyone else to fight over the remaining 24%. Their toolkit:

- **Point of View (POV):** a manifesto that frames a *problem*, the *cost of not solving it*, a *vision of the future*, and your unique answer. It declares what you stand for and against.
- **The enemy / old way vs. new way:** you attack the customer's *status quo* (the "old game"), credibly showing it's now unwinnable, and name the "new game" — the category itself. Drift did this with **Conversational Marketing** (enemy = lead-capture forms); Gong did it with **Revenue Intelligence** (enemy = guesswork sales calls).
- **The Lightning Strike:** one concentrated, all-in campaign that makes your POV "the talk of the town" and anchors the new category in buyers' minds.

School B — Position Inside an Existing Category (Dunford / Grenier / Ross)

The counter-school says category creation is a trap for almost everyone:

- **April Dunford** (*Obviously Awesome*) favors **niching down**: use what customers *already* understand about a market, then "narrow the field of alternatives to a niche where your product is much better for a *particular kind of buyer*." Her example: don't sell "a database," sell "an embeddable database for mobile devices." Creating a new category means you "first have to make the category mean something in the customer's mind" — expensive, slow, risky.
- **Louis Grenier** (Everyone Hates Marketers) is blunt: true category creation is impractical for ~99% of B2B companies. It needs **$100M+ and 6–10 years**; demand is created by tectonic shifts (tech, regulation, culture), *not* by a company declaring a category. Instead, **own a segment**: be the obvious choice for one specific buyer with an ignored, painful struggle. He requires the segment be (1) specific enough to win, (2) painful enough to drive a purchase, (3) connected enough for word-of-mouth.
- **Aaron Ross / Jason Lemkin** (*From Impossible to Inevitable*) call **"Nail a Niche"** the #1 missing growth ingredient — Salesforce started with sales-force automation, Amazon with books, Facebook with Ivy League schools. Win one niche completely, *then* expand.

The synthesis (and the honest answer): these schools agree more than they appear to. The smart early-stage move is to **borrow category design's *narrative weapons* (enemy, old-vs-new, promised land) while playing Dunford/Grenier's *segment-ownership game*.** You sound like a category creator; you spend like a niche-dominator.

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2. So which should Print-Flow-360 do?

Verdict: Own the segment. Do NOT create a new category. Here's the reasoning specific to us:

Test	Print-Flow-360 reality	Implication
Does demand already exist?	**Yes.** 72%+ of print companies had adopted web-to-print by end of 2024; the market is ~$1.47B (2024) growing ~7.4% CAGR.	Demand exists → don't pay to *create* it. Capture it.
Does the buyer know the category word?	**Yes** — "web-to-print" is a term shop owners already search and use.	No re-education cost. Creating a new word would *hurt* discoverability.
Do we have $100M and 6–10 years?	**No.** Early-stage.	Category creation is off the table financially.
Is there an *ignored, painful* sub-segment?	**Yes.** Incumbents (OnPrintShop, DesignNBuy, Aleyant/Pressero, Infigo) explicitly target "B2B and B2C printers, resellers, brokers, in-plant, enterprise, trade." They sell to people who can configure, integrate, and pre-check artwork. **The non-technical solo/small shop owner is underserved and intimidated by them.**	This is our segment. Specific, painful, connected (shop owners talk to each other).

We pass every Grenier test for *segment ownership* and fail every test for *category creation*. The decision makes itself.

The nuance that makes us look like a category creator anyway: we can *brand* our segment as if it were a category — give it a name, a POV, an enemy. That's the "category-design-lite" or "own-a-segment-loudly" move. We get 80% of the narrative power for 1% of the cost.

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3. Our candidate narrative (draft — refine, don't ship verbatim)

Category/segment name (the shelf, sharpened)

"Web-to-print for shops, not developers." (Working tagline.) Alternatives to A/B test: *"The web-to-print that runs your shop, not your IT department,"* or the noun-form segment label **"Owner-run web-to-print."** Keep the words *web-to-print* in it — that's the discoverable category word; the modifier is where we plant our flag.

One-line POV / narrative

> *"Selling print online shouldn't require hiring a developer. Print-Flow-360 is the web-to-print platform a shop owner sets up themselves — storefront, live pricing, and a customer design studio — without code, agencies, or a six-week onboarding."*

The named enemy

The enemy is **not Vistaprint and not OnPrintShop** (never name a competitor — it's salesy and elevates them). The enemy is the **status quo belief the owner carries: "going online means hiring a developer, paying an agency, or losing every job to Vistaprint."** Sub-villains that dramatize it: the **six-figure custom build**, the **enterprise platform that needs an IT person to configure**, and the **"just use Vistaprint" surrender** that hands a local shop's customers to a faceless giant.

Old way vs. new way

The old way (the enemy)	The new way (Print-Flow-360)
"Online = hire a developer / agency"	Set it up yourself, by intuition, in an afternoon
Enterprise platforms built for trade printers & IT teams	Built for the owner who answers the phone *and* runs the press
Weeks of onboarding, manuals, config screens	Plain-language setup; defaults that fit 90% of shops
Lose local jobs to Vistaprint's scale	Keep your customers, your brand, your margins — online
Customers email you messy files	Customers design it themselves in your studio; you get print-ready output

The narrative arc (problem → stakes → promised land → product as bridge)

1. **The big change (undeniable, not about us):** Your customers now expect to order business cards, banners, and flyers online at 11pm — the same way they order everything else. Walk-in-and-wait is no longer how buying happens.
2. **The stakes:** Every job you can't take online is a job Vistaprint *will*. The local shop's biggest asset — being the trusted neighborhood printer — is invisible online, so the giant wins by default. Do nothing and you slowly become a finishing house for other people's online orders.
3. **The false summit (the enemy):** "Going online" has meant one of three bad options: pay an agency $10–30k, wrestle an enterprise platform that assumes you have an IT person, or give up and resell Vistaprint. All three say the same thing to a shop owner: *this isn't built for you.*
4. **The promised land:** Your own branded storefront where customers configure, price, and **design** their own business cards and banners — and you wake up to print-ready orders. You set it up yourself. No code, no agency, no IT hire. You compete with the giants on *your* turf — local trust — at *their* convenience level.
5. **Product as the bridge:** Print-Flow-360 is the only web-to-print platform designed for the non-technical shop owner to run end-to-end alone: live pricing engine, embedded design studio, orders and print-job tracking, B2B accounts, payments — all driven by plain-language screens, not config files.

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4. Concrete tactics — executable this week

- **Rewrite the homepage hero** to lead with the enemy + promised land, not features. Headline candidate: *"Sell print online without hiring a developer."* Subhead names the three bad old options and our one new way.
- **Publish a POV essay / manifesto** ("The web-to-print software market forgot the shop owner") on the site and LinkedIn. This is the cheap version of a Lightning Strike: one sharp argument, repeated everywhere, not a paid blitz.
- **Build one comparison asset, framed by buyer-fit, not feature checklists:** "Built for trade printers & IT teams vs. built for owner-run shops." Never trash competitors by name — frame them as great-but-for-someone-else.
- **Pick the wedge product:** lead with the *single most intuitive* job (e.g., "your own online business-card store, live in an afternoon") rather than the whole platform. Nail one niche use-case the way Ross/Lemkin prescribe.
- **Collect "old way" horror quotes** from real shop owners ("an agency quoted me $18k") — these become the most persuasive proof the enemy is real.
- **Make the product *prove* the POV.** Per our own §0 UX standard, every screen must be plain-language and intuitive — because the moment a non-technical owner hits a `slug` or a config wall, the narrative ("built for you, not developers") is exposed as a lie.

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5. Metrics / KPIs to track

What it tells you	KPI
Is the segment narrative resonating?	Homepage → trial conversion rate after the rewrite (target a clear lift vs. current)
Are we reaching the *right* buyer?	% of sign-ups self-identifying as solo/small independent shops (≤ ~10 staff)
Does the "no developer" promise hold?	Self-serve activation rate: % who get a storefront live **without** support contact
Is word-of-mouth (Grenier's "connected") working?	% of new accounts from referral / "another shop told me"
Are we *owning* the word?	Share of voice for "web-to-print for small print shops" / branded search volume growth
Message-market fit, qualitatively	5 customer-language interviews per month: do they repeat our old-vs-new framing back to us unprompted?

6. Common mistakes / anti-patterns to avoid

- **Inventing a jargon category name.** Don't coin "PrintCommerce-as-a-Service." A new word you have to define = expense and confusion. Keep "web-to-print"; modify it.
- **Naming a competitor as the enemy.** It's salesy, it advertises *them*, and it invites a feature war you can't yet win. The enemy is the owner's status-quo belief.
- **Confusing a category with a tagline.** The POV must live in the product, pricing, onboarding, and sales script — not just the homepage banner.
- **Trying to serve everyone in the category.** The moment we chase trade printers, brokers, and enterprise in-plant (where OnPrintShop/DesignNBuy already dominate), we lose the one thing we own: *being unmistakably for the small non-technical shop.* Resist it until the niche is won.
- **Mistaking a feature blitz for a Lightning Strike.** With limited budget, our "strike" is a *sharp repeated argument*, not a paid saturation campaign. Concentration of *message*, not spend.
- **Shipping UX that contradicts the story.** A "no developer needed" promise dies on the first UUID, error code, or empty state. The narrative and the §0 UX bar are the same project.

7. Bottom line

Print-Flow-360 should **own a segment loudly** — be the undisputed "web-to-print for non-technical, owner-run print shops" — and wrap it in full category-design *narrative* (named enemy = the developer-and-agency status quo; old-way-vs-new-way; a promised land where the local shop beats the giants on its own turf). We get the gravitational pull of category design without the fatal cost of category *creation*, because the demand and the category word already exist. Our job is not to invent the shelf. It's to become the only obvious choice on it for the buyer everyone else built *past*.

Further reading / sources

- Play Bigger — *What is Category Design / POV / Lightning Strike*: https://www.playbigger.com/categorydesign and https://www.playbigger.com/category-design
- April Dunford, *Obviously Awesome* (niche-down vs. category creation) — quickstart: https://www.aprildunford.com/post/a-quickstart-guide-to-positioning ; summary: https://www.kathirvel.com/guide-april-dunford-positioning-framework/
- Louis Grenier (STFO), *Stop Trying To Create A Category. Own A Segment Instead.*: https://www.stfo.io/articles/category-creation/
- Aaron Ross & Jason Lemkin, *From Impossible to Inevitable* ("Nail a Niche"): https://fromimpossible.com/ ; summary: https://www.blinkist.com/en/books/from-impossible-to-inevitable-en
- Andy Raskin, *The Greatest Sales Deck / strategic narrative* (big change, name the enemy, promised land): https://medium.com/firm-narrative/pitch-like-moses-87540a85b236 and https://andyraskin.com/
- Andy Raskin, *To Create a New Category, Name the New Game*: https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/create-new-category-name-game-andy-raskin
- B2B Category Design + 76% market-value stat: https://www.sproutworth.com/b2b-category-design/
- Web-to-print market size & adoption (≈$1.47B 2024, 7.4% CAGR, 72%+ adoption): https://www.marketgrowthreports.com/market-reports/web-to-print-software-market-105273
- Competitive landscape (OnPrintShop, DesignNBuy, Aleyant, EFI MarketDirect, segment targeting): https://www.danetsoft.com/post/8-best-onprintshop-alternatives-for-web-to-print-businesses-in-2026 and https://www.designnbuy.com/blog/best-web-to-print-softwares
- HubSpot's Dharmesh Shah on category creation as higher-risk/higher-reward: https://freshcodeit.com/freshcode-post/startup-category-creation

Cold Email & Outbound Deliverability: A Safe Playbook for Reaching Print Shop Owners

Source: readme/research/marketing/COLD_EMAIL_AND_DELIVERABILITY_2026-06-16.md

IN SHORT — KEY TAKEAWAYS

This document explains how to send cold emails to local print shop owners without getting blocked or ending up in their spam folder. It matters because local print shops are hard to reach through ads or Google — but they do check their business email every day, so a well-sent email is one of the best ways to book your first meetings.

The main parts explained simply:

- **Email authentication (SPF, DKIM, DMARC)** — These are three short settings you add to your domain's internet records. They prove to Gmail and Yahoo that your emails are real and not fake or spam. Without them, your emails get blocked automatically. Google and Yahoo made these required in 2024.
- **Use a separate sending domain** — Never send cold emails from your main business address (like `printflow360.com`). If a campaign goes wrong and gets marked as spam, it will ruin your main domain too — including password-reset and order emails. Instead, buy a cheap separate domain (like `getprintflow.com`, about $10/year) just for outreach.
- **Domain warm-up** — A brand-new email address has no history, so email providers don't trust it yet. You need to spend 2–3 weeks slowly sending small amounts of email to build trust before contacting real prospects. Special tools do this automatically.
- **List cleaning** — Before you email anyone, run your list through a checking tool to remove bad addresses. Emailing addresses that don't exist damages your reputation fast. A clean list keeps your bounce rate (the percentage of failed emails) under 1%.
- **Email sequence (what to send and when)** — Send 4–5 short emails spread over about 3 weeks, each one adding something new — not just "just following up." The first email should be plain text, short, and sound like a real person wrote it. Each email in the series should give the reader a reason to reply.
- **Sending platform** — Use a dedicated tool like Smartlead or Instantly (about $37–40/month) that automatically spreads your emails across several inboxes so you never send too many from one address at once. This is safer and gets better results.
- **Warning signs to watch daily** — If more than 1% of your emails bounce (fail to deliver) or more than 0.1% of people mark you as spam, stop sending immediately and fix the problem before continuing. Pushing through these limits will get your domain blacklisted.
- **Legal rules** — Cold B2B email is legal in the US if you include your real mailing address, make it easy to unsubscribe, and honor unsubscribe requests quickly. Ignoring these rules can result in large fines. Canada has stricter rules — start with US shops to keep things simple.
- **Common mistakes to avoid** — Sending from your main domain, skipping warm-up, not cleaning the list, sending too many emails from one inbox, and using emails that look like marketing flyers (images, lots of links) are the most common ways people end up in spam or get their domain blacklisted permanently.

What to do with this: Buy a cheap separate sending domain, set up the three authentication records (SPF, DKIM, DMARC), run a 2–3 week warm-up period, clean your prospect list before sending, then

> start with a small, personal email sequence of 4–5 messages spaced over three weeks. Watch bounce and spam rates every day, and stop immediately if either goes too high.

TL;DR: Cold email still works for reaching local print shop owners in 2026 — but only if you treat deliverability as an engineering problem, not a copywriting one. Buy a *separate* sending domain, authenticate it perfectly (SPF + DKIM + DMARC), warm it for 2–3 weeks, send tiny daily volumes from a verified clean list, and use a multi-step sequence with real personalization. Do this and you land in the inbox; skip any step and you land in spam permanently. This doc gives you exact DNS records, a sequence template, a volume ramp, guardrail metrics, and a legal checklist.

> **Why this matters for Print-Flow-360:** Your buyer (a non-technical local print shop owner) does not search "web-to-print SaaS" on Google — so inbound won't reach them at the start. They *do* have a public business email (often listed on Google Maps), they check it daily, and they're reachable one-to-one. Cold email is the single most founder-controllable, low-cost channel to book your first 20–50 demos. But Google/Yahoo tightened bulk-sender rules in 2024 and enforce them now: one bad campaign can torch your main domain's reputation and your transactional/onboarding emails. **Cold outbound must run on isolated infrastructure that can never poison `printflow360.com`.**

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1. The non-negotiable foundation: authentication

Mailbox providers (Gmail, Yahoo, Outlook) decide *before a human ever sees your email* whether to inbox, spam-folder, or reject it. The decision is driven by three DNS records. Define each below.

Record	What it does (plain language)	Why you need it
SPF (Sender Policy Framework)	A DNS list of which servers are *allowed* to send mail "from" your domain	Stops spoofers; required by Google/Yahoo
DKIM (DomainKeys Identified Mail)	A cryptographic signature proving the email wasn't altered in transit	Proves the mail is genuinely yours
DMARC (Domain-based Message Authentication)	A policy telling receivers what to do if SPF/DKIM fail, plus a reporting address	Required by Google/Yahoo since Feb 2024; gives you visibility

Google & Yahoo bulk-sender rules (2024+, enforced now)

The hard line is **5,000 emails/day to Gmail addresses** — above it you're a "bulk sender" with strict obligations. But you should follow all of these from email #1:

- **SPF *and* DKIM both required** (not one or the other).
- **DMARC published** with at least `p=none`.
- **One-click unsubscribe** (RFC 8058 `List-Unsubscribe` header) on bulk mail, honored within **2 days**.

- **Spam complaint rate below 0.10%**, and *never* above 0.30% — 0.3% is where enforcement (throttling/rejection) begins, so treat **0.1% as your ceiling**, not a target.

Example DNS records for Print-Flow-360

Assume your cold-outbound domain is **`getprintflow.com`** (a *separate* domain — see §2). Add these TXT records at your registrar:

SPF (host: `@` / root):

```
v=spf1 include:_spf.google.com include:amazonses.com -all
```

(Include only the senders you actually use; `-all` = "reject everything else." Keep it under 10 DNS lookups.)

DKIM — generated by your sending provider; you paste a record like (host: `google._domainkey`):

```
v=DKIM1; k=rsa; p=MIGfMA0GCSqGSIb3DQ...<long public key>...
```

DMARC (host: `_dmarc`):

```
v=DMARC1; p=none; rua=mailto:dmarc@getprintflow.com; aspf=r; adkim=r; fo=1
```

Start at `p=none` to monitor for ~2–3 weeks via the aggregate (`rua`) XML reports, confirm all your legit mail passes, then tighten to `p=quarantine` and eventually `p=reject`. Use a free/low-cost DMARC monitor (PowerDMARC, dmarcian, or Postmark's free DMARC tool) to read the XML reports — they're unreadable raw.

BIMI (the brand-logo-in-inbox feature) is a *later* nice-to-have. It requires `p=quarantine` or `p=reject` enforcement **plus** a paid Verified Mark Certificate (VMC, ~$1,000+/yr from DigiCert/Entrust). **Skip BIMI for cold outbound entirely** — it's a brand-trust play for your *main* domain once you're at scale, not a deliverability lever for prospecting.

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2. Sending infrastructure: isolate everything

Rule #1: never send cold email from `printflow360.com`. If a campaign gets flagged, you don't want your password-resets, order confirmations, and trial-onboarding emails landing in spam.

The setup:

1. **Buy 1–3 dedicated cold domains** — close-variant or "+marketing" style: `getprintflow.com`, `tryprintflow.com`, `printflow-hq.com`. ~$10–15/yr each at Namecheap/Cloudflare. These are disposable reputation buffers.
2. **2–3 mailboxes per domain**, max. Use a real human's name: `pravin@getprintflow.com`, `pg@getprintflow.com`. Avoid `info@`, `sales@`, `noreply@` (spam-correlated).

3. **One inbox = max ~20–40 emails/day** after warm-up. Most operators cap at **~20–30/day per inbox** for safety even fully warmed. To send 100 cold emails/day you need **~4–5 inboxes**, rotated.
4. **Use Google Workspace inboxes** (~$6/user/mo) for best Gmail-to-Gmail placement, *or* a dedicated cold-email infra provider that spins up pre-warmed mailboxes.
5. **Set up forwarding/redirects** from the cold domains to your real site so links and replies work.

This whole setup costs roughly **$100–200/mo** at the scale you need — trivial against one closed SaaS subscription.

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3. Domain warm-up: earn reputation before you ask for anything

A brand-new domain has zero sending reputation. Blast 100 cold emails on day one and you're flagged instantly. **Warm up for 2–3 weeks minimum** before any real prospect gets an email.

Warm-up tools (Instantly's warmup, Smartlead's warmup, Mailwarm, TrulyInbox) auto-send small volumes between a pool of real inboxes that open, reply, and mark "not spam" — simulating genuine engagement. Then ramp your *real* cold volume gradually:

Period	Cold emails/day **per inbox**	Notes
Weeks 1–2 (warm-up only)	0 real / ~10–20 warm-up	No prospecting yet
Weeks 3–4	5–10	Begin real sends, monitor closely
Weeks 5–6	15–25	Scale if metrics are clean
Week 7+	25–40 (cap ~30 for safety)	Steady state

Even at steady state, keep **10–20% of daily volume as ongoing warm-up** to maintain positive engagement signals.

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4. List hygiene: the #1 cause of dead domains

A high **bounce rate** (emails to addresses that don't exist) is the fastest way to get your domain blacklisted. Most providers flag senders above a **2% bounce rate**; you want to stay **under 1%**.

Build + clean the print-shop list:

1. **Source the list.** Local print/sign/copy shops are physical businesses with strong Google Maps presence. Use a Google Maps scraper (Apify's local-business-lead-miner, Targetron, or Livescraper) to pull *name, address, phone, website, and listed email* by searching "print shop" / "sign shop" / "copy center" across target metros. Supplement with B2B directories (MerchantCircle, Local.com, USCity) and Apollo.io's database (also gives firmographic filters).
2. **Verify every address before sending.** Run the raw list through a verifier to drop invalid/risky addresses:

- **MillionVerifier** — cheapest at ~$37/10k, ~96% accuracy, refunds credits for unknown/catch-all (conservative, good for tight budgets).
- **ZeroBounce** — ~99.6% accuracy, spam-trap + abuse detection (premium).
- **NeverBounce** — fast bulk + real-time API for high volume.

Recommendation: MillionVerifier for your early scale — the price/accuracy is right and it won't gamble on catch-alls.

3. **Drop these categorically:** role addresses (`info@`, `sales@`) where possible, catch-all domains flagged risky, anything verifier-marked invalid/unknown, and known spam traps.
4. **Re-verify** any list older than ~30 days before reusing.

A typical unverified scraped list bounces ~5%; verified, it drops under 1%. That single step is the difference between a domain that lasts and one that dies in week two.

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5. Sequencing & copy for print shop owners

Cadence (the "3-7-7" pattern): 4–6 emails over ~14–21 days, with *widening gaps*. 2025 benchmarks show ~93% of replies arrive by day 17. Send Tue–Thu mornings in the prospect's timezone.

Step	Day	Goal
1	0	Hook + one specific, relevant problem
2	3	New angle (not a "bump")
3	8	Social proof / concrete result
4	14	Short, low-friction ask
5	21	Polite break-up

Write for a non-technical shop owner. No jargon ("multi-tenant," "web-to-print," "SaaS"). Talk about *their* day: walk-in customers asking "can I order online?", emailing PDFs back and forth, re-typing business-card orders.

Example sequence copy (personalize the bracketed bits per-shop — real personalization drives ~52% higher replies than merge tags alone):

> **Email 1 — Subject:** `quick question about [Shop Name]` Hi [First Name], Saw [Shop Name] does business cards and banners for [Town] — nice work on [specific: the site / a Google review / a product]. Quick question: when a customer wants to reorder cards or upload their own design, do they have to come in or email you a file? We help shops like yours put that whole thing online — customers pick the product, see the price, and even design it themselves, no developer needed. Worth a 10-min look? — Pravin *[plain-text signature, physical address, one-click unsubscribe]*

Email 2 (Day 3) — Subject: `re: ordering online for [Shop Name]` Hi [First Name], following up with something concrete: [comparable shop / segment] put their catalog online and now takes reorders overnight without the back-and-forth. Happy to show you exactly how it'd look for [Shop Name]'s products. Open to a quick screen-share this week?

Email 3 (Day 8) — Subject: `the design-it-yourself part` The piece shops love most: customers design their own cards/flyers right on your site and you get a print-ready file. No more chasing PDFs. 2-minute video here: [link]. Want me to set up a free demo store with your products in it?

Email 4 (Day 14) — Subject: `should I close your file?` Hi [First Name] — don't want to clutter your inbox. If online ordering isn't a priority right now, just say the word and I'll stop. If it is, reply "show me" and I'll send a demo. Thanks either way.

Copy rules to stay out of spam: plain text (no images/heavy HTML in step 1), one link max early on, no spam-trigger words ("free!!!", "guarantee", "act now", "$$$"), short paragraphs, a real signature with physical address + unsubscribe. Every follow-up must add *new information*, not re-greet.

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6. The sending platform

You need a tool that handles multi-inbox **rotation** (spreading sends across your 4–5 inboxes), warm-up, sequencing, and reply detection.

Tool	Best for	Entry price	Notes
Smartlead	Best deliverability + unlimited inbox rotation, fine throttling	~$39/mo	Highest measured inbox placement (~87%); plug in your own SES
Instantly	Simplicity + scale, beginner-friendly UX	~$37/mo	Unlimited rotation on higher tier; great for first-timers
Lemlist	Multichannel + dynamic personalization	~$59/mo	Stronger personalization, pricier
Apollo	Built-in B2B data + sending in one place	varies	Best if you also want it as your *data* source

Recommendation: Start with **Smartlead or Instantly**. If you want list-sourcing + sending in one tool to move faster, **Apollo** doubles as your data layer. Pair whichever you pick with **MillionVerifier** for cleaning.

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7. Metrics, guardrails & kill-switches

Watch these daily. The first three are *safety* metrics — breach them and **pause immediately**, don't push through.

Metric	Healthy	Warning	STOP & fix
Bounce rate	< 1%	1–2%	> 2% (pause, re-verify list)
Spam complaint rate	< 0.1%	0.1–0.3%	> 0.3% (pause domain, audit copy/targeting)
Reply rate	5–10%+	2–4%	< 1% (targeting/copy problem)
Open rate *(soft signal)*	40%+	20–40%	< 20% (deliverability problem)
Positive reply / demo rate	track per campaign	—	—

B2B cold reply benchmarks run 3–5% average; tight ICP + real personalization gets top performers to 15–25%. Smaller, well-targeted campaigns beat broad blasts ~2.76x — so segment by shop type (sign shops vs. business-card shops) and tailor.

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8. Legal compliance checklist (B2B cold email)

Cold B2B email is legal in the US, EU, and Canada *with conditions*. Do all of these:

- [ ] **CAN-SPAM (US):** truthful "From"/subject, **physical mailing address** in every email, clear opt-out honored within **10 business days**. Penalties run up to ~$53,088 *per email*.
- [ ] **One-click unsubscribe** header + visible opt-out link; suppress opt-outs permanently across all campaigns/domains.
- [ ] **GDPR (EU prospects):** rely on **legitimate interest** — email professional addresses only, keep messages relevant to the person's job, disclose how you got their data, document a **Legitimate Interest Assessment** per campaign, honor opt-outs in **24–48 hrs**. Penalties up to €20M / 4% turnover.
- [ ] **CASL (Canada — strictest):** needs express or **implied consent** (e.g. a published business email + conspicuous publication, or existing business relationship). If unsure about Canadian shops, **exclude them** until you have a clean basis. Up to ~CAD $10M penalties.
- [ ] **Maintain a master suppression list** (opt-outs + bounces) applied across every domain and tool.

Pragmatic stance: Focus your first campaigns on **US (and your home market)** local shops where CAN-SPAM compliance is straightforward. Add EU with documented legitimate interest later; treat CASL/Canada cautiously.

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9. Prioritized action checklist (this week → next month)

Week 1 — Infrastructure

1. Buy 1–2 cold domains (`getprintflow.com` , `tryprintflow.com`).
2. Set up Google Workspace, 2–3 named inboxes per domain.
3. Publish SPF, DKIM, DMARC (`p=none`) per §1. Verify with MXToolbox.
4. Connect inboxes to Smartlead/Instantly; turn on warm-up.

Weeks 1–3 — Warm-up + list 5. Let warm-up run untouched 2–3 weeks. 6. Scrape + build a 500–1,000 print-shop list (Apify/Targetron/Apollo). 7. Verify it through MillionVerifier; cut to clean addresses only. 8. Build a master suppression list.

Week 4 — Launch 9. Load the 4-step sequence (§5), personalize per shop. 10. Start at 5–10 emails/inbox/day, Tue–Thu mornings. 11. Watch the guardrail dashboard daily (§7); pause on any red.

Ongoing 12. Ramp volume weekly only while bounce <1% and complaints <0.1%. 13. Move DMARC to `p=quarantine` once reports are clean. 14. Re-verify any list >30 days old; iterate copy on reply data.

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10. Common mistakes / anti-patterns

- **Sending cold from your main domain** — the #1 unrecoverable mistake. Always isolate.
- **Skipping warm-up** — instant spam-folder for a new domain.
- **Not verifying the list** — high bounces blacklist you within days.
- **One inbox, high volume** — 100/day from one mailbox screams “spammer.” Rotate across many low-volume inboxes.
- **HTML-heavy, image-laden, multi-link emails** — looks like marketing, filtered as marketing. Keep step 1 plain text.
- **“Just following up” bumps** — every step must add new value.
- **Ignoring the metrics** — pushing through a 3% bounce rate to “hit a number” kills the domain.
- **Spray-and-pray** — broad blasts underperform tight, segmented, personalized campaigns ~3x.
- **No physical address / no unsubscribe** — straight CAN-SPAM violation at up to $53k/email.

Further reading / sources

- Google/Yahoo & Microsoft Bulk Sender Requirements (2026 guide) — Unboxd
- Gmail & Yahoo Bulk Sender Requirements (updated) — EmailWarmup
- Cold Email Deliverability Best Practices 2025 — SuperSend
- Cold Email Sending Limits: 2025 Playbook — Topo
- Email Warm-up Best Practices 2025 — Mailpool
- DMARC Record Examples & Configurations — EmailTooltester
- Why BIMI Needs a Strict DMARC Policy — ZeroHook
- 2026 Email Verification Benchmark — Instantly

- MillionVerifier vs ZeroBounce — Sparkle
- Cold Email Sequence Best Practices 2025 — SuperSend
- Cold Email Reply-Rate Benchmarks 2025 — The Digital Bloom
- Cold Email Compliance Checklist: CAN-SPAM, GDPR, CASL 2025 — Mailpool
- GDPR, CAN-SPAM & B2B List Compliance — Instantly
- Best Cold Email Software 2026 (Instantly/Smartlead/Apollo) — Unify
- Build a B2B Prospect List from Google Maps — Botsol
- Google Maps Scraper for B2B Leads — Apify

DecoNetwork Alternative for Apparel & Print Shops — Print-Flow-360

Source: readme/research/marketing/COMPARISON_DECONETWORK_ALTERNATIVE_2026-06-16.md

IN SHORT — KEY TAKEAWAYS

This document is a ready-to-publish web page aimed at shop owners who are unhappy with DecoNetwork (a popular software for apparel and print shops) and are searching for a better option. It explains, clearly and honestly, where Print-Flow-360 is stronger and where DecoNetwork is still the right pick.

The main parts explained simply:

- **Who DecoNetwork is for** — DecoNetwork is built specifically for shops that do screen printing, embroidery, and garment decoration. It has deep tools for that niche. This page targets their frustrated customers, not all of DecoNetwork's users.
- **The two main complaints about DecoNetwork** — Customers find its design tool hard to use (leading to abandoned orders), and the pricing is confusing — there is a one-time license fee on top of the monthly price, and the exact amount is not publicly stated.
- **Why the comparison page leads with the design studio** — Print-Flow-360 has a "personalize mode" where customers just fill in their name or text on a locked template, plus a live 3D preview of the product. The argument is: an easier design tool = more orders completed = more sales for the shop owner.
- **Transparent pricing as a selling point** — DecoNetwork charges a monthly fee plus an extra one-time fee (amount hidden). Print-Flow-360 publishes one flat monthly price with no hidden setup cost. The page uses this as a trust point.
- **B2B (business customers) built in** — Print-Flow-360 includes tools for selling to companies: order approvals, department budgets, and pay-on-account credit. DecoNetwork is lighter on these features.
- **The honest "where DecoNetwork wins" section** — The page openly says: if you need specialist embroidery/screen-print production workflows, deep digitizing software links (Wilcom/Corel), CMYK print-ready files, or real carrier shipping with tracking, DecoNetwork is still the better fit right now. Print-Flow-360 does not yet have those.
- **Gaps called out clearly** — The document flags that Print-Flow-360 currently lacks: CMYK/preflight output, live carrier shipping and tracking, destination-based tax, and partial order fulfillment. These are listed so the marketing page stays honest, not oversold.
- **Accuracy warnings for the team** — Before publishing, prices and the one-time fee claim must be verified on DecoNetwork's own site, because review samples are small and the fee amount is not confirmed.

What to do with this:

Fill in the bracketed placeholders (monthly price, trial length) with real numbers before publishing. Only use this page if your shop actively targets apparel and garment decoration customers — it is written specifically for that audience, not general commercial print shops.

> **Type:** Publish-ready BOFU comparison page (Bet 2) — draft copy for the marketing site. **Companion:** `readme/ACQUISITION_EXECUTION_KIT_2026-06-16.md` (skeleton §7) · sibling page `COMPARISON_ONPRINTSHOP_ALTERNATIVE_2026-06-16.md`. **Target query:** "DecoNetwork alternative" / "DecoNetwork pricing" / "DecoNetwork reviews". **Use only if pursuing the apparel/decoration vertical** (screen print, embroidery, DTG/DTF). DecoNetwork is apparel-niche, not general commercial print.
>
> ⚠️ **Accuracy notes — read before publishing:**
>
> - DecoNetwork reviews are **polarized** (Capterra ~3.9, ease-of-use ~3.6, ~24 reviews — a modest sample). Say "based on a modest number of reviews," don't imply statistical weight.
> - DecoNetwork **publishes tiers** (~$239/$339/$439/mo, month-to-month) **but adds an undisclosed one-time license fee** (third-party cites ~$999, unconfirmed). Frame the fee as "a one-time license fee on top of the monthly, amount not publicly stated" — don't assert $999 as fact.
> - The recurring, citable complaint is **design-tool usability** ("Designer is awful, customers couldn't use it") and **performance lag on save** + **price increases**. These are fair wedges.
> - **Do NOT claim apparel-production superiority.** DecoNetwork is a purpose-built apparel-decoration platform (Wilcom/Corel integration, decoration-specific workflows). Print-Flow-360 has a t-shirt product type + designer but is **not** an apparel-decoration MIS — keep the honest "where DecoNetwork is better" section.
> - Same PF360 gaps as the OnPrintShop page (no CMYK/preflight, no carrier shipping, no destination tax, no partial fulfillment) — don't claim them. Fill `[…]` placeholders with verified numbers.

Looking for a DecoNetwork alternative?

DecoNetwork is a capable, apparel-focused platform — but if you've used it, two things probably brought you here: **a design studio your customers find hard to use**, and a price that's gone up (with a one-time license fee layered on top of the monthly).

If you want a **modern, easy-to-use store you can launch yourself, on a price you can see in full, with a design tool customers actually finish their orders in**, Print-Flow-360 is worth a look.

> **In one line:** Print-Flow-360 gives apparel and print shops a fast, self-serve online store with a customer-friendly design studio and transparent pricing — no surprise license fee.

[See your shop's store in 10 minutes →] · free trial, no card

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At a glance

	Print-Flow-360	DecoNetwork
Best for	Shops wanting a fast, easy, modern store + real B2B	Apparel-decoration shops wanting decoration-specific workflows
Pricing	Published — **[$X/mo]**, no setup/license fee	~$239–439/mo **+ an undisclosed one-time license fee**
Free trial	**Yes — [14-day], no card**	14-day grace period (not a clear free trial)
Ease of use	Built for non-technical owners	Ease-of-use rated ~3.6; "steep learning curve" is common
Customer design studio	Studio + personalize mode + 3D preview, built to be finishable	Yes, but **usability is a recurring complaint**
Performance	Modern Nuxt 4 stack	Reviewers note **lag on save**
Apparel-decoration workflow	T-shirt product + designer (general)	**Purpose-built** — screen print/embroidery/DTG, Wilcom/Corel
B2B accounts	Approvals, budgets, pay-on-account included	Affiliate/multi-store; lighter on corporate approvals
Hosting	Cloud SaaS, isolated per store	Hosted SaaS + layered license fee

DecoNetwork figures are from public vendor pages and independent reviews (Capterra/Software Advice); the one-time license fee amount is not publicly stated. Modest review sample.

Why shops switch from DecoNetwork to Print-Flow-360

1. A design studio your customers can finish their order in

The most consistent independent criticism of DecoNetwork is that its **designer is hard for customers to use** — and a design tool customers abandon is lost orders. Print-Flow-360's studio is built around getting the customer to "done": **personalize mode** (lock the layout, the customer just fills in name/number/text), clear upload-artwork flow, and a **live 3D preview** so they see the shirt before they buy.

2. One clear price — no surprise license fee

DecoNetwork publishes monthly tiers but adds a **one-time license fee on top** (amount not stated publicly), and reviewers have flagged **price increases**. Print-Flow-360 publishes **[$X/mo]** with **no setup or license fee** — the number you see is the number you pay.

3. Launch it yourself, today

No onboarding sessions to schedule, no learning curve to climb before go-live. Guided setup, a seeded sample store, and plain-language settings get you live the **[same day]**.

4. A modern, fast admin

Reviewers mention DecoNetwork **lagging on save** and a dated feel. Print-Flow-360 runs on a modern Nuxt 4 stack with a clean, responsive admin built for daily use.

5. Real B2B built in

Corporate accounts, **order approvals**, **department budgets**, and **pay-on-account credit** — included, not an add-on.

6. Pricing that matches print math

12 pricing strategies — area-based, quantity-tier breaks, formulas, option add-ons, combination matrix — with a live breakdown the customer sees as they configure.

Where DecoNetwork is the better choice (the honest part)

Choose DecoNetwork if your shop is apparel-decoration-first and you need:

- **Decoration-specific production workflows** — screen printing, embroidery, DTG/DTF as first-class flows, with **Wilcom/Corel** integration for digitizing. Print-Flow-360 has a general t-shirt product + designer, not a decoration-specialist MIS.
- **Print-ready / CMYK output and preflight today** — Print-Flow-360 outputs RGB; CMYK and automated preflight are on the roadmap, not shipped.
- **Carrier shipping & tracking, partial fulfillment, destination-based tax** — DecoNetwork and MIS-grade tools handle these now; Print-Flow-360 currently does flat/tiered shipping, single flat tax, and one atomic order status.
- **Affiliate/fundraising multi-store networks at scale** — a DecoNetwork strength.

If those decoration-production capabilities are table-stakes for you right now, DecoNetwork is a strong fit and we'd say so.

FAQ

Is Print-Flow-360 cheaper than DecoNetwork? DecoNetwork lists ~$239–439/mo plus a one-time license fee (amount not stated). Print-Flow-360 is **[$X/mo]** with no setup or license fee and a free trial — compare the all-in cost yourself.

Will my customers find the design tool easy? That's the point of difference — Print-Flow-360's **personalize mode** lets customers just fill in their details on a locked template, and a **3D preview** shows the finished product. DecoNetwork's designer is its most-criticized area.

Can it do apparel decoration? It supports t-shirt/garment products and customer design. But if you need deep screen-print/embroidery/DTG production workflows and digitizing integrations, DecoNetwork is the specialist (we say so above).

Can I move from DecoNetwork? Yes — run a free trial alongside your current store, rebuild your top products (we'll help), and switch when you're ready. No card to try it.

[See your shop's store in 10 minutes →] · free trial, no card

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Comparison compiled June 2026 from DecoNetwork's public vendor pages and independent reviews (Capterra, Software Advice). Pricing and the one-time license fee may change and the fee amount is not publicly stated — verify on their site. Review sample is modest. Print-Flow-360 roadmap items (CMYK/preflight, carrier shipping, destination tax, partial fulfillment, decoration-specific workflows) are called out as not-yet-available.

InkSoft Alternative for Apparel & Merch Shops — Print-Flow-360

Source: readme/research/marketing/COMPARISON_INKSOFT_ALTERNATIVE_2026-06-16.md

IN SHORT — KEY TAKEAWAYS

This document is a ready-to-publish webpage that Print-Flow-360 can put on its marketing site to attract apparel and merch shop owners who are unhappy with InkSoft and searching for a better option. It explains, honestly and in plain language, where Print-Flow-360 wins, where InkSoft is still stronger, and what a shop owner should do next.

The main parts explained simply:

- **What InkSoft is** — InkSoft is a popular online store and design tool for printed clothing and branded merchandise. It is now owned by a larger company called Inktavo. Many shop owners like its design tool but complain that the price keeps going up and features sometimes disappear without warning.
- **Why shops look for an alternative** — The main reasons people leave InkSoft are: the monthly cost has risen, the communication around price changes was poor, and the setup feels heavier than expected for a small shop.
- **Price clarity and stability** — Print-Flow-360 publishes its price upfront and commits to not removing features you rely on. This directly addresses InkSoft's most-cited pain point.
- **Self-serve, same-day setup** — A shop owner can sign up, get a sample store already filled with products, and go live the same day — no project plan, no waiting for help.
- **Built-in B2B tools** — Corporate customer accounts, manager order approvals (orders wait for sign-off before being charged), department spending limits, and credit accounts are all included, not sold as extras.
- **Flexible print pricing** — 12 different ways to price products (by size, by quantity, by formula, by option add-ons), with a live price breakdown shown to the customer while they configure their order.
- **One platform, one login** — InkSoft is one piece of a larger software suite; Print-Flow-360 covers storefront, design studio, products, orders, and B2B in a single place with a single bill.
- **Honest "InkSoft is better" section** — The page admits InkSoft's design studio is genuinely strong and is the right pick if a shop needs CMYK print-ready files, carrier shipping, or full production management (screen print / embroidery workflows).

What to do with this:

Fill in the placeholder prices and trial length (marked `[$X/mo]` and `[same-day]` in the draft), verify InkSoft's current pricing on their website before publishing, and only publish this page if Print-Flow-360 is actively targeting the apparel and merch market.

Type: Publish-ready BOFU comparison page (Bet 2) — draft copy for the marketing site.
Companion: `readme/ACQUISITION_EXECUTION_KIT_2026-06-16.md` (skeleton §7) · sibling pages:

> OnPrintShop & DecoNetwork alternatives. **Target query:** “InkSoft alternative” / “InkSoft pricing” / “InkSoft reviews”. **Use only if pursuing the apparel/merch vertical.** InkSoft = decorated apparel + promo products; now part of Inktavo (sister product to Printavo).
>
> ⚠️ **Accuracy notes — read before publishing:**
>
> - InkSoft’s **design studio is praised** in independent reviews (“insanely cool”, “powerful”). **Do NOT compete on “our studio is better.”** Compete on **price transparency, pricing stability (no yanked features/quiet hikes), self-serve, non-technical UX, and B2B depth.**
> - Verified pricing point: **“$299/mo flat, month-to-month.”** Other tiers ($314/$419) and any free trial/version are **single-aggregator / unverified** — don’t state as fact.
> - Fair, citable complaints: **“overpriced/complicated,” price increases with poor communication, features removed in updates, glitchy, limited customization/integrations, dropped Canadian tax.** Review samples are small (Capterra ~4.0 of 12, G2 ~3.3 of 12) — say so.
> - InkSoft is **part of Inktavo** (merged with OrderMyGear ~Oct 2025 per a snippet — verify the date before citing).
> - Same PF360 gaps apply (no CMYK/preflight, no carrier shipping, no destination tax, no partial fulfillment, not an apparel-decoration MIS) — keep the honest “where InkSoft is better” section. Fill `[…]` placeholders.

Looking for an InkSoft alternative?

InkSoft has a genuinely strong design studio — that’s not in question. What brings shops looking for an alternative is usually the rest of the package: **a price that’s risen (with communication people didn’t love), features that have changed under them, and a setup that feels heavier than “just launch my store.”**

If you want a **modern store you can stand up yourself, on a transparent price that won’t surprise you, with real B2B built in**, here’s an honest comparison.

> **In one line:** Print-Flow-360 is a fast, self-serve online store for apparel and merch shops with transparent, stable pricing and deep B2B — no surprise hikes, no yanked features.

[See your shop’s store in 10 minutes →] · free trial, no card

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At a glance

	Print-Flow-360	InkSoft
Best for	Shops wanting self-serve setup, stable pricing, real B2B	Merch/apparel shops wanting a polished design studio + Inktavo suite
Pricing	Published — **[$X/mo]**, transparent	~$299/mo flat (verified); other tiers unverified
Pricing stability	One clear price, no feature removals	Reviewers cite **hikes + removed features**
Free trial	**Yes — [14-day], no card**	Unverified
Setup	Self-serve, **[same-day]**, seeded sample store	Self-serve builder + ~5h onboarding; tailored stores slower
Design studio	Studio + personalize mode + 3D preview	**Strong / praised** — a genuine InkSoft strength
B2B accounts	Approvals, budgets, pay-on-account included	Group/company stores; lighter on corporate approvals
Ecosystem	Self-contained platform	Part of Inktavo (Printavo/GraphicsFlow)
Hosting	Cloud SaaS, isolated per store	Cloud SaaS

InkSoft figures are from public vendor pages and independent reviews (Capterra/G2); most pricing detail is single-source/unverified and review samples are small.

Why shops consider Print-Flow-360 over InkSoft

1. Transparent, stable pricing

The sharpest InkSoft complaints are about **price increases communicated poorly** and **features changing in updates**. Print-Flow-360 publishes **[$X/mo]** up front, and our standard is not to pull features out from under you. You can compare the real cost before you commit.

2. Launch it yourself, the same day

InkSoft is self-serve but tailored stores take time and onboarding. Print-Flow-360 seeds a complete sample store on signup and uses plain-language settings, so a branded store can be live the **[same day]** with no project plan.

3. Real B2B, built in

Corporate accounts with **negotiated pricing**, **order approvals** (held for a manager before charging), **department budgets**, and **pay-on-account credit** with terms — included, not a separate product in a suite.

4. Pricing that matches print math

12 pricing strategies (area-based, quantity-tier breaks, formulas, option add-ons, combination matrix) with a live breakdown the customer sees while configuring.

5. One self-contained platform

InkSoft is one piece of the Inktavo suite (with Printavo for back-office). Print-Flow-360 gives you the storefront, design studio, products/pricing, orders, and B2B in a single platform with one login and one bill.

Where InkSoft is the better choice (the honest part)

Choose InkSoft (or the Inktavo suite) if:

- **The design studio is your top priority.** InkSoft's is genuinely well-reviewed; if studio polish for decorated merch is the deciding factor, it's a strong pick.
- **You want the full Inktavo back-office** — pairing InkSoft's storefront with **Printavo's MIS** (scheduling, production tracking, invoicing) as one ecosystem.
- **You need print-ready CMYK output and preflight today** — Print-Flow-360 outputs RGB; CMYK/preflight are roadmap.
- **You need carrier shipping & tracking, partial fulfillment, or destination-based tax now** — Print-Flow-360 does flat/tiered shipping, single flat tax, and one atomic order status today.
- **You're decoration-production-first** (screen print/embroidery/DTG workflows at depth) — that's the merch-suite's home turf.

If those are must-haves right now, InkSoft/Inktavo is a credible choice and we'd point you there.

FAQ

Is Print-Flow-360 cheaper than InkSoft? InkSoft's verified price is ~$299/mo flat (other tiers unverified). Print-Flow-360 is **[$X/mo]**, published, with a free trial — compare directly.

Is the design tool as good as InkSoft's? InkSoft's studio is genuinely strong — we won't pretend otherwise. Print-Flow-360's adds **personalize mode** and **live 3D preview**; if studio polish is your single deciding factor, try both. Where we pull ahead is transparent/stable pricing, self-serve speed, and built-in B2B.

Will the price or features change on me? Our standard is transparent pricing and not removing features you rely on — a specific pain point in InkSoft reviews.

Can I move from InkSoft? Yes — run a free trial alongside your current store, rebuild your top products (we'll help), switch when ready. No card to try it.

[See your shop’s store in 10 minutes →] · free trial, no card

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Comparison compiled June 2026 from InkSoft’s public vendor pages and independent reviews (Capterra, G2). Most pricing detail is single-source/unverified, review samples are small, and InkSoft is part of Inktavo — verify current details on their site. Print-Flow-360 roadmap items (CMYK/preflight, carrier shipping, destination tax, partial fulfillment, decoration-specific workflows) are called out as not-yet-available.

OnPrintShop Alternative for Small Print Shops — Print-Flow-360

Source: readme/research/marketing/COMPARISON_ONPRINTSHOP_ALTERNATIVE_2026-06-16.md

IN SHORT — KEY TAKEAWAYS

This document is a side-by-side comparison of Print-Flow-360 and OnPrintShop — two software platforms that help print shops sell online. It is written as a marketing page aimed at shop owners who are researching OnPrintShop and wondering if there is a simpler, more affordable option.

The main parts explained simply:

- **What each platform is best for** — OnPrintShop suits larger or trade printers who have time and budget for a guided setup. Print-Flow-360 is built for the owner who wants to set up their own online store quickly, without needing technical skills or a sales call.
- **Pricing transparency** — OnPrintShop does not show its prices publicly; you have to contact their sales team. Print-Flow-360 shows its price upfront and offers a free trial with no credit card needed.
- **How fast you can launch** — With Print-Flow-360 you can have a working, branded store live the same day. OnPrintShop's setup typically involves their team and can take many hours across days or weeks.
- **Ease of use for non-technical owners** — Print-Flow-360 is designed so that someone who has never used shop software before can figure it out on their own. OnPrintShop is powerful but reviewers mention a learning curve, and knowing some web code helps.
- **Whole-store branding from one color** — Pick your brand color once in Print-Flow-360 and the entire storefront — buttons, links, highlights — automatically matches. No design work needed.
- **Customer design tool** — Both platforms let customers design their own products online. Print-Flow-360 adds a "personalize mode" (customers just fill in their name or text on a locked template) and a live 3D preview of the finished product.
- **Pricing that matches how print shops quote** — Print-Flow-360 supports 12 ways to price a job (by area, quantity breaks, formulas, add-ons, and more) so quotes match real print pricing without manual calculation.
- **B2B / business customer features** — Corporate accounts, order approvals, department budgets, and credit terms (buy now, pay later) are all included.
- **Where OnPrintShop is genuinely better** — If you need press-ready CMYK files (professional print color), automatic carrier shipping rates, or complex production workflows, OnPrintShop is ahead. Print-Flow-360 is honest about these gaps and lists them clearly.

What to do with this: Use this page to decide which platform fits your shop right now. If you need a quick, affordable, easy-to-run online store, Print-Flow-360 is the faster path. If you need advanced print-production features today, OnPrintShop may be the better fit until Print-Flow-360's roadmap catches up.

> **Type:** Publish-ready BOFU comparison page (Bet 2, asset #1) — draft copy for the marketing site, not internal docs. **Companion:** strategy `readme/ACQUISITION_CHANNELS_2026-06-15.md` · execution kit `readme/ACQUISITION_EXECUTION_KIT_2026-06-16.md` (skeleton §7). **Target query:** “OnPrintShop alternative” / “OnPrintShop pricing” / “OnPrintShop reviews”. **Primary CTA:** *See your shop’s store in 10 minutes* → demo/trial.
>
> ⚠️ **Accuracy notes for whoever publishes this — read first:**
>
> - OnPrintShop is **well-rated** (G2 ~4.5, Capterra ~4.4–4.6). This page competes on **transparency, self-serve speed, non-technical usability, and modern UX** — *not* by bashing quality. Keep it fair; fairness ranks and converts.
> - OnPrintShop’s **pricing is not publicly listed** (4 “contact sales” tiers; third-party estimates ~$199–250/mo, ~20–80h bundled setup). Everything about their price/setup below is phrased as “not publicly listed / third-party estimate” — **do not state their prices as fact.**
> - **Do NOT claim print-production superiority.** OnPrintShop has **300 DPI CMYK/RGB print-ready output and a mature preflight/imposition pipeline**; Print-Flow-360 does **not** yet (no preflight/CMYK, no carrier shipping, no destination tax, no partial fulfillment — see the honest “Where OnPrintShop is the better choice” section, which is deliberately included and must stay).
> - Fill the bracketed `[…]` placeholders (price, trial length, time-to-launch) with verified Print-Flow-360 numbers before publishing.

Looking for an OnPrintShop alternative?

If you run a small or growing print shop and you’re weighing OnPrintShop, you’ve probably hit the same three questions everyone does: **What does it actually cost? How long until my store is live? And will my team — and my customers — find it easy to use?**

OnPrintShop is a capable, well-reviewed platform, especially for trade printers and larger operations with the time and budget for a guided rollout. But if you’re a **non-technical owner who wants to launch a branded online store yourself, in an afternoon, on a price you can see before you talk to sales**, Print-Flow-360 is built for exactly that.

This page lays out an honest, side-by-side comparison — including the cases where OnPrintShop is the better fit.

> **In one line:** Print-Flow-360 is the fastest way for a non-technical print shop to launch a branded online store and start taking orders — with transparent pricing, self-serve setup, and a design studio your customers can actually use.

[See your shop’s store in 10 minutes →] · no card, nothing to cancel

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At a glance

	Print-Flow-360	OnPrintShop
Best for	Non-technical owners who want to self-launch a branded store fast	Trade printers & larger PSPs with budget for a guided rollout
Pricing	Published, self-serve — **[$X/mo]**, see it before you buy	Not publicly listed; 4 “contact sales” tiers (3rd-party est. ~$199–250/mo)
Free trial	**Yes — [14-day], no card**	No free trial / free version (per vendor)
Time to launch	**[Same day]** — guided setup + sample store seeded for you	Implementation-assisted; tiers bundle ~20–80h setup + 12–36h training
Made for non-technical owners	Core design principle — plain language, no code	Powerful, but reviewers note a learning curve (CSS/HTML helps)
Brand your whole store	One color rebrands the entire storefront	Themed; customization available
Customer design studio	Fabric.js studio + 3D preview, built to be customer-friendly	Yes — HTML5 designer, strong reviews
Print-ready output (CMYK / preflight)	**Not yet** (RGB; on roadmap)	**Yes — 300 DPI CMYK/RGB, mature preflight/imposition**
Pricing engine	12 pricing strategies (area, tiers, formulas, matrix)	Flexible pricing engine (well-reviewed)
B2B accounts	Corporate accounts, approvals, budgets, pay-on-account	B2B-capable (B2B-heavy customer base)
Hosting	Cloud SaaS, isolated per store	Cloud SaaS (AWS)

OnPrintShop figures are from public vendor pages and independent reviews (G2/Capterra); pricing and setup hours are vendor-gated or third-party estimates, not confirmed list prices.

Why shops choose Print-Flow-360 over OnPrintShop

1. You can see the price — and start — without a sales call

OnPrintShop’s plans are “contact sales,” with setup and training hours bundled into higher tiers. That’s normal for enterprise software, but it’s friction when you just want to know if this fits your budget this month. **Print-Flow-360 publishes its pricing and lets you start a free trial with no card.** What you see is what you pay — no hidden license or setup fee.

2. You launch it yourself, the same day

OnPrintShop’s tiers bundle implementation and training hours because it’s built to be rolled out *with* their team. Print-Flow-360 is **self-serve**: a guided setup wizard, a fully seeded sample store (products, categories, pricing, statuses) the moment you sign up, and plain-language settings — so you can have a real, branded store live in an afternoon, not a project plan.

3. It's built for a non-technical owner

The single most common note in independent OnPrintShop reviews is a **learning curve** — knowing some CSS/HTML helps, and the admin "could be more streamlined." Print-Flow-360's entire design standard is the opposite: intuitive placement, plain-language labels (no UUIDs, slugs, or jargon on screen), and every screen made discoverable without training.

4. One color rebrands your whole store

Drop in your brand color and the **entire storefront recolors** — buttons, links, accents, everything — so your store looks like *your* shop, not a template, in seconds.

5. A design studio your customers can actually use

Both platforms have a customer-facing design studio. Print-Flow-360's is built around the cases that matter for a shop: upload artwork, **personalize mode** (lock the layout, let the customer just fill in name/phone on a template), multi-page products (front/back), live **3D preview** on the real product, and export to PDF/PNG/SVG.

6. Pricing that matches how print shops actually quote

12 pricing strategies — **area-based** for wide format, **quantity-tier breaks**, **formula** pricing, option add-ons, and a **combination matrix** — with a live price breakdown the customer sees as they configure. The same calculator runs on the product page, cart, checkout, and your admin, so quotes never drift.

7. Real B2B, not bolted on

Corporate accounts with **negotiated pricing**, **order approvals** (a buyer's order is held for a manager before it's charged), **department budgets**, and **pay-on-account credit** with terms (Net 30) and a running statement.

Where OnPrintShop is the better choice (the honest part)

We'd rather you pick the right tool than churn in a month. **Choose OnPrintShop (or another mature MIS-grade platform) if:**

- **You need print-ready output today.** OnPrintShop produces **300 DPI CMYK/RGB print files** and has a mature **preflight and imposition** pipeline. Print-Flow-360 outputs RGB today; CMYK conversion and automated preflight are on our roadmap, not shipped. If files must hit your RIP press-ready, OnPrintShop is ahead here.
- **You need carrier shipping & tracking.** OnPrintShop integrates real shipping workflows. Print-Flow-360 currently supports flat/tiered/free-threshold shipping only — no live UPS/FedEx/USPS rates or automatic tracking numbers yet.

- **You're a trade printer needing partial fulfillment, split shipments, or production scheduling.** These are core to large-run and reseller operations, and OnPrintShop/MIS-grade tools handle them today; Print-Flow-360 treats an order as one unit for now.
- **You need destination-based tax (US nexus / EU VAT / GST) out of the box.** Print-Flow-360 supports a single flat tax rate per store today.
- **You want a guided, done-with-you implementation** rather than setting it up yourself.

If those are table-stakes for your shop right now, OnPrintShop is a strong, well-reviewed choice and we'd genuinely point you there.

Where Print-Flow-360 pulls ahead

- **Transparent, self-serve pricing** with a real free trial — no sales gate.
- **Same-day, do-it-yourself launch** — no implementation hours to buy.
- **Built for non-technical owners** — plain language, no code, no learning curve.
- **Whole-store rebrand from one color**, plus a 37-block drag-and-drop page builder.
- **Customer-friendly design studio** with personalize mode + live 3D preview.
- **12 pricing strategies** that match real print quoting.
- **Deep B2B** — approvals, budgets, pay-on-account — included, not an add-on.
- **AI product builder** — type "black hoodie," get the matched product and a ready-to-edit design.

Frequently asked questions

Is Print-Flow-360 cheaper than OnPrintShop? OnPrintShop doesn't list public prices (third parties estimate ~$199–250/mo with bundled setup hours). Print-Flow-360's pricing is published at **[$X/mo]** with a free trial and no setup fee — so you can compare for yourself before committing.

How long does it take to launch a store? With Print-Flow-360 you can have a branded store live the **[same day]** — setup is self-serve and your account comes pre-loaded with a sample store you customize. OnPrintShop is implementation-assisted, with setup and training hours bundled into its plans.

Do my customers get a design tool? Yes — both platforms include a customer-facing design studio. Print-Flow-360's adds a **personalize mode** (lock the layout, let customers just fill in their details) and a **live 3D preview** of the finished product.

Can it handle B2B / corporate customers? Yes — corporate accounts, negotiated pricing, order approvals, department budgets, and pay-on-account credit are all included.

Can it output CMYK / print-ready files? Not yet — Print-Flow-360 outputs RGB today; CMYK and automated preflight are on the roadmap. If you need press-ready CMYK now, OnPrintShop is stronger here (we say so above).

Can I move from OnPrintShop? Yes — start a free trial alongside your current setup, rebuild your top products (we'll help), and switch when your store's ready. No card to try it.

[See your shop's store in 10 minutes →] · free trial, no card, nothing to cancel

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Comparison compiled June 2026 from OnPrintShop's public vendor pages and independent reviews (G2, Capterra, Software Advice). Competitor pricing and setup hours are vendor-gated or third-party estimates and may change — verify current details on their site. Print-Flow-360 capability claims map to shipped features; roadmap items (CMYK/preflight, carrier shipping, destination tax, partial fulfillment) are called out as not-yet-available.

Demand Generation vs. Demand Capture: A Two-Track Growth Playbook for Print-Flow-360

Source: readme/research/marketing/DEMAND_GEN_VS_CAPTURE_2026-06-16.md

IN SHORT — KEY TAKEAWAYS

This document explains two very different ways to find new customers — and why you need both running at the same time. Most print shop owners have never searched for “web-to-print software” because they don’t know that kind of tool exists for them. If you only advertise to people who are already looking, you can only ever reach a tiny slice of the market. This document shows how to reach the rest.

The main parts explained simply:

- **The 95/5 rule** — At any given moment, only about 5% of print shop owners are actively shopping for a new tool. The other 95% haven’t even thought about it yet. This is the most important number in the whole document — it explains why relying on Google ads alone will always hit a ceiling.
- **Demand capture (reaching the 5% who are searching)** — These are shop owners who already know they want something better. You reach them with comparison pages (“Print-Flow-360 vs OnPrintShop”), a clear pricing page, listings on review sites like G2 and Capterra, and a small amount of Google advertising on very specific search terms.
- **Demand generation (reaching the 95% who aren’t searching yet)** — These shop owners don’t know they have a problem you can fix. You reach them by showing up in the Facebook groups and trade communities where print owners already hang out, answering their questions helpfully, and posting short videos showing how easy it is to take orders online — without a developer.
- **Where to spend your time and money** — Early on, put roughly 65% of effort into capture (it shows results fast) and 30% into community and content (it builds slowly but lasts longer). Most of the community work costs time, not money.
- **How to know what’s actually working** — Your analytics tools will under-count word-of-mouth and community referrals. The single best fix: add a plain “How did you hear about us?” question to your sign-up form and read every answer. Also watch how many people search your brand name by name — that number rising means word-of-mouth is spreading.
- **Common traps to avoid** — Don’t pitch your product inside print communities; just help people first for weeks before mentioning it. Don’t use jargon like “web-to-print SaaS” — say “sell online without a developer” instead. Don’t expect community effort to show results this month; it pays off over many months.

What to do with this: Add a “How did you hear about us?” field to your sign-up form today — it takes an hour and is the highest-value single action. Then build three comparison pages (vs your closest competitors) and join five to eight print-owner Facebook groups with the goal of helping, not selling.

TL;DR: Only ~5% of print shops are actively shopping for web-to-print software right now. You must run two engines at once: a **capture** engine (SEO, comparison pages, paid search) to win the 5% already searching, and a **generation** engine (founder POV in print communities, education, word-of-mouth) to plant the idea in the 95% who haven't realized they can sell online without a developer. At pre-seed/seed stage, weight effort ~70% to capture (proves the business works fast) and ~30% to generation (builds the compounding moat), and trust self-reported attribution ("How did you hear about us?") over your analytics dashboard.

> **Why this matters for Print-Flow-360** Our buyer — a non-technical local print shop owner — is the textbook "latent demand" customer. Most of them have never typed "web-to-print software" into Google because they don't know the category exists or assume online ordering means "hire a developer for $20k." If we only build a capture machine, we'll fight Vistaprint, OnPrintShop, and Pressero over the tiny pool of already-convinced searchers. The real, less-contested opportunity is *creating* the realization — "you can run an online print store yourself, this week, no developer." That is demand generation, and it's where a focused early-stage founder wins.

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1. The core distinction (taught plainly)

Demand capture = catching people who already know they have a problem and are actively looking for a solution. They're "in-market." Your job is to be *found* and to *win the comparison*.

Demand generation = creating awareness, education, and preference *before* someone is shopping — so that when they eventually go in-market, your name is the first one they think of. Chris Walker of Refine Labs popularized this "create demand / capture demand" split and frames the modern operating model as **Brand → Demand → Expand**: build preference before buyers are in-market, capture high-intent demand efficiently, then expand post-sale (Refine Labs).

The classic analogy: Tesla spent ~8–10 years *creating* demand for electric vehicles — millions of people who didn't want an EV a decade ago now do. That's generation. A Google search for "Tesla Model 3 price" is capture.

The 95/5 Rule — the single most important number here

Research from Professor John Dawes at the **Ehrenberg-Bass Institute** (amplified by the **LinkedIn B2B Institute**) found that at any given moment only ~**5%** of B2B buyers are in-market; the other **95% are out-of-market** (LinkedIn B2B Institute; Ehrenberg-Bass). The math: if a shop owner re-evaluates their online-storefront setup once every ~5 years, only ~20% are "in-market" in a given year and ~5% in a given quarter.

Implication for us: Pure capture tactics can only ever reach 5% of the addressable market at once. If we ignore the 95%, we cap our own ceiling. The winning move is to *increase the probability that "Print-Flow-360" is the name that comes to mind* when a shop owner finally decides "we need to sell online."

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2. Map our buyers: who's in-market vs. latent

Segment	In-market?	What they're doing	Track
The frustrated DIYer	✅ In-market (the 5%)	Already tried/uses a clunky web-to-print tool (OnPrintShop, Pressero) or a generic Shopify build that can't price print jobs; searching for alternatives	**Capture**
The "we need a website" shop	🟡 Edge of market	Knows they need *something* online, Googling vaguely ("print shop website", "sell business cards online"), but doesn't know "web-to-print" is a category	**Capture + Gen**
The "online is for big guys" shop	❌ Latent (the 95%)	Runs everything by phone/email/walk-in; believes selling online = expensive developer project; doesn't know self-serve SaaS exists for them	**Gen**
The growth-curious owner	❌ Latent	Watches competitors, reads industry FB groups, anxious about losing jobs to Vistaprint, but hasn't connected that to a software fix	**Gen**

The market context is favorable: ~72% of printing companies had adopted some web-to-print by end of 2024, and ~50% of new small/mid printers cite web-to-print as their **top investment** (Global Growth Insights; PrintPlanr). That means in-market demand is real and growing — but the *non-technical independent shop* is exactly the under-served slice the incumbents (built for tech-comfortable mid-market) talk past. That gap is our generation wedge.

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3. The Capture Stack (catch the 5% who are searching)

Capture is high-ROI and fast — BOFU (bottom-of-funnel) comparison and pricing pages can show results in 30–60 days because they target buyers already evaluating (CXL). High-commercial-intent keywords convert ~10x better than informational ones. Build, in priority order:

1. **Comparison / "alternative" pages.** The single highest-leverage capture asset. Create honest pages: *"Print-Flow-360 vs OnPrintShop," "OnPrintShop alternative for small print shops," "Pressero alternative," "DesignNBuy vs Print-Flow-360," "Shopify for print shops — why it falls short on pricing."* People search these with wallet out.
2. **BOFU money keywords.** Target solution + intent modifiers: "web to print software," "online ordering system for print shops," "print shop ecommerce platform," "web to print with design tool." Each gets a dedicated, conversion-optimized page (demo CTA, screenshots, "go live this week").
3. **Pricing page that ranks.** Many search "[product] pricing" / "web to print software pricing." A clear, public-ish pricing page captures this and pre-qualifies.
4. **Paid search on the same terms** — small, tightly-scoped budget on the 10–20 highest-intent keywords above. Don't broaden; in-market volume is thin, so spend only where intent is unmistakable.
5. **Software directories & review sites.** Get listed and gather reviews on **G2, Capterra, GetApp, Software Advice, and Trustpilot** — these rank for our category terms and are where in-market buyers

validate. Aim for 10+ reviews before chasing paid placement.

6. **Retargeting** demo-page visitors who didn't convert (cheap, high-intent).

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4. The Generation Stack (create demand in the 95%)

This is the harder, more durable engine. Demand creation for vertical SaaS runs on **founder credibility + community + education**, not search ads — because the audience isn't searching (Insight Partners; DemandZen). It spreads through **dark social** — word-of-mouth, group shares, DMs that never show up in analytics (Refine Labs).

Go where print shop owners already gather:

- **Facebook Groups** are the beating heart of this trade — e.g. *Screen Print Pros*, sign/print/promo-product owner groups where members troubleshoot business problems daily (Printavo). Join, *help genuinely* (answer pricing/turnaround/online-ordering questions), don't pitch. This is where preference is built.
- **Trade associations & events** — PRINTING United, FESPA, PSDA, regional print associations. Vertical SaaS thrives at industry events where buyers congregate (Wikipedia: FESPA; PSDA). Even a single regional trade show booth or sponsored local meetup beats broad ads.
- **Founder POV content.** The founder (or a named face of Print-Flow-360) posts short, opinionated, plain-language content on LinkedIn, YouTube, and inside those FB groups: *"How a 2-person print shop took its first online order in a weekend," "Why Vistaprint is eating your business-card walk-ins — and what to do about it," "You don't need a developer to sell online."* Teach the realization, don't sell the SKU.
- **Show, don't tell.** 60–90 second screen-recorded demos: "Build a business-card product with live pricing in 4 minutes." Non-technical owners believe what they *see* working.
- **Founder-led outreach.** At our stage, the founder personally DMing/calling/visiting local shops and *listening* is itself demand gen — every conversation plants the idea and yields content.

The message that creates demand for us: not "buy web-to-print software" (category language they don't use) but **"You can run your own online print store yourself — no developer, no Vistaprint cut, live by next week."** That reframes a non-problem into an urgent one.

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5. Budget / effort split for early stage

Generic frameworks (Binet & Field's 60/40 brand/performance) are derived from *established* companies and are a trap for a seed-stage startup chasing product-market fit (First Round Review). The stage-appropriate guidance: pre-seed/seed should be heavily performance/capture-weighted (~70–90%) because capture gives instant proof the business works.

Recommended split for Print-Flow-360 (now → next ~12 months):

Engine	Effort/$	Why
Capture	**~60–70%**	Fast proof, lowest CAC, validates messaging and ICP. Build the comparison/BOFU pages + directory presence first.
Generation	**~25–30%**	Mostly *founder time*, not cash — community participation, POV content, demos. Compounds slowly; start now so it's mature when you scale.
Tooling/experiments	**~5–10%**	Analytics, a CRM, "How did you hear about us?" capture, small test budgets.

Crucially, the generation 30% is mostly **time, not money** at this stage — perfect for a founder. As capture saturates the thin 5% pool, shift the mix toward generation.

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6. Attribution: don't get fooled

Software-based attribution (Google Analytics, ad-platform dashboards) is **heavily biased toward capture** — it credits the last clicked ad and is blind to the FB-group comment or founder post that actually created the demand (Refine Labs hybrid attribution). Companies waste budgets because dashboards "manufacture data to pretend something works." The fix Refine Labs recommends:

- **Add a "How did you hear about us?" free-text field** on every demo request and sign-up. This *self-reported attribution* is your single best read on whether generation is working.
- **Watch branded search volume** — when generation works, people start Googling "Print-Flow-360" by name. Rising branded/direct traffic is the clearest proxy for upper-funnel effectiveness (Dreamdata).
- **Don't kill a generation program because the dashboard shows zero conversions** — by design it won't show them.

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7. Metrics & leading indicators

Capture (lagging, fast):

- Demo requests / sign-ups from BOFU pages & paid search
- Keyword rankings for comparison/money terms; G2/Capterra review count & rating
- Cost per demo, demo → paid conversion rate

Generation (leading, slow):

- **Branded search volume** for "Print-Flow-360" (Google Search Console) — *the* north-star leading indicator
- **Direct + organic non-branded traffic** trend
- Share of demo requests citing community/founder content in "How did you hear about us?"
- FB-group/LinkedIn engagement: questions answered, DMs, "someone in my group recommended you"
- Inbound from people who *weren't searching* (word-of-mouth referrals)

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8. Common mistakes / anti-patterns

- **All-capture tunnel vision.** Optimizing only for the 5% caps your ceiling and traps you in a price/feature war with incumbents over already-convinced buyers.
- **Pitching in communities.** Print FB groups will eject you instantly if you sell. Help first, for months, before anyone clicks a link.
- **Trusting the dashboard over self-reported attribution.** You'll defund the exact program (founder POV, community) that's quietly driving word-of-mouth.
- **Speaking in category jargon.** "Web-to-print SaaS" means nothing to a latent shop owner. Generation content must use *their* words ("sell online," "stop losing walk-ins to Vistaprint").
- **Applying enterprise brand benchmarks (60/40) at seed.** Burns runway on awareness before you've proven capture economics.
- **Expecting generation to pay off this quarter.** It compounds over quarters/years (Tesla took ~8–10). Start now precisely *because* it's slow.
- **Inconsistent founder presence.** One viral post, then silence. Generation is a drumbeat, not a campaign.

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9. Prioritized action checklist (start this week)

1. **Add "How did you hear about us?"** to the demo/sign-up form today. (1 hour, highest-leverage single action.)
2. **Ship 3 comparison pages:** vs OnPrintShop, OnPrintShop-alternative-for-small-shops, Shopify-for-print-shops. (Capture, fast ROI.)
3. **Claim & populate G2, Capterra, GetApp** profiles; ask your first happy users for reviews.
4. **Join 5–8 print/sign/promo Facebook groups** and the relevant subreddits; spend 2 weeks just *helping* before posting anything about the product.
5. **Record one 90-second demo:** "Build a business-card product with live pricing in 4 minutes." Post it natively in those communities and on LinkedIn.
6. **Founder publishes 1 POV post/week** in plain language ("You don't need a developer to sell print online").
7. **Stand up Google Search Console** and start a weekly log of branded-search volume — your generation north star.
8. **Run a tiny paid-search test** ($300–500/mo) on the 10 highest-intent keywords only; measure cost per demo.
9. **Pick one regional print trade event** to attend (not exhibit yet) and talk to 20 owners — research + relationships + content fuel.

Further reading / sources

- LinkedIn B2B Institute — The 95-5 Rule
- Ehrenberg-Bass Institute — The 95:5 Rule: Why B2B Growth Starts Long Before the Purchase
- Refine Labs / Chris Walker and the Hybrid Attribution Framework
- CXL — Bottom-of-Funnel Content for B2B SEO
- Insight Partners — Top 3 questions founders have about SaaS B2B demand gen
- DemandZen — Vertical SaaS & Community
- First Round Review — Performance vs. Brand Marketing for Startups
- Dreamdata — Brand vs. Demand Marketing
- Global Growth Insights — Web to Print Software market & adoption
- Printavo — Top Facebook Groups for Screen Printers

Free Standalone Design Tool — Engineering-as-Marketing Spec

Source: readme/research/marketing/FREE_DESIGN_TOOL_SPEC_2026-06-16.md

IN SHORT — KEY TAKEAWAYS

This document explains a plan to offer a free online design tool — like a business-card maker or flyer maker — that anyone can use without signing up. The goal is to bring new visitors to the platform through Google, let them experience the design studio for themselves, and then gently invite them to start their own print store. It matters because it turns the design studio we already built into a marketing engine.

The main parts explained simply:

- **The free tool idea** — Give people a free “business card maker” or “flyer maker” on a public webpage. No login needed to design. This attracts people searching Google for those exact phrases and lets them try the studio with zero risk.
- **What we already have** — The design studio (the editor where you add text, images, and shapes) already exists and works well. Most of the hard work is done. The new effort is mostly about wrapping it in a public page and adding a sign-up step.
- **The sign-up gate** — People can design freely without an account. The moment they want to download or save their design, they see a simple “create a free account to get your file” screen. Once they sign up, they get their file — and a gentle invitation to start a free store trial.
- **SEO (getting found on Google)** — Each free tool gets its own dedicated page with a web address like `/tools/business-card-maker`. These pages are written so Google can find and rank them for popular searches like “free business card maker.” Every starter template also gets its own page, creating many more chances to be found.
- **Tracking the funnel** — Every step a visitor takes is recorded: did they visit the page, start a design, try to download, create an account, start a trial? This tells us whether the free tool is actually bringing in new paying customers or just free users.
- **Limits and safety rules** — Uploaded files are stored only briefly and cleaned up automatically. The tool is limited so it cannot be abused for free unlimited work. Mobile phones can use it too, even if some advanced features require a desktop.
- **Build order** — Start with just two product types (business card and flyer). Get the anonymous design mode working first, then the landing pages, then the sign-up gate, then tracking. Add more product types later.

What to do with this: The first step is making the design studio work without needing a store account — that is the only genuinely new technical piece. Once that works, everything else (the landing pages, the sign-up gate, the templates) is relatively quick to add on top. Start there.

> **Type:** Product-build spec for Bet 2's top-of-funnel magnet (the highest-leverage SEO + demo asset). **Companion:** strategy `readme/ACQUISITION_CHANNELS_2026-06-15.md` · kit `readme/ACQUISITION_EXECUTION_KIT_2026-06-16.md` §8. **Thesis:** Expose the existing **Fabric.js design studio** (`designer/`) as a free, no-login tool (a business-card / flyer maker). It is simultaneously (a) a search-traffic magnet for high-volume "free X maker" queries, (b) a live, hands-on demo of our single biggest differentiator, and © the top of a funnel that converts a slice of designers into store trials. This is the Ahrefs/Canva "free tool" playbook applied to our own engine.
>
> **Status:** spec only — not built. This documents *what to build and why*, grounded in what already exists in the repo. Hand to engineering as the brief.

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1. Why this asset (and why it's cheap)

We already own the hard part. The `designer/` app (Vue 3 + Fabric.js, port 5174) is a battle-tested editor with text, shapes, images, filters, multi-page templates, undo/redo with IndexedDB crash recovery, and export to PNG/JPG/SVG/PDF. A free standalone tool is mostly **packaging + gating + SEO surface**, not a new product.

Three returns from one build:

1. **SEO / traffic** — "free business card maker", "free flyer maker", "online [product] designer" are high-volume, evergreen queries. Free tools are link magnets (Ahrefs' free tools out-pull its blog).
2. **Live demo** — instead of a screenshot, the prospect *uses* the studio. The "wow" of our differentiator is experienced, not described.
3. **Funnel** — a soft, well-placed gate converts a fraction of designers into account/trial signups, attributable end-to-end.

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2. What’s already there vs. what’s new

Capability	Exists in `designer/`?	Work for the free tool
Canvas editor (text/shapes/images/filters)	✅	Reuse as-is
Templates / clipart / asset library	✅	Curate a free starter set per product
Multi-page (front/back)	✅	Limit to 1–2 pages for v1
Undo/redo + crash recovery	✅	Reuse
Export PNG/JPG/SVG/PDF	✅	Gate export (see §4)
No-login / anonymous session	⚠️ designer assumes a product/template context	**New:** standalone entry, anonymous local draft
Public marketing route + SEO	❌	**New:** indexable landing pages per tool
Soft signup gate at export/save	❌	**New:** account-create wall on export
Analytics / attribution	⚠️	**New:** UTM + event instrumentation (§6)
Tenant-less mode	❌ (designer runs in tenant context)	**New:** a landlord/marketing context, no tenant required

Architectural note (important): the studio normally runs embedded in a tenant storefront. The free tool runs on the **marketing/landlord** surface with **no tenant**. Decide early where it’s hosted (marketing site subpath, e.g. `/tools/business-card-maker`) and ensure the anonymous design path does not require `InitializeTenancy` or a tenant-scoped upload pipeline. Anonymous uploads should go to a **landlord/marketing bucket with short TTL auto-cleanup**, not a tenant bucket.

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3. Scope — v1 (ship small)

Product types: start with **2** — business card + flyer. (Highest search volume, simplest geometry.) Add t-shirt and poster in v2.

Per tool:

- A dedicated, indexable landing page (`/tools/business-card-maker`, `/tools/flyer-maker`).
- “Start designing — free, no signup” CTA opening the canvas with that product’s dimensions + bleed/safe guides preset.
- A curated gallery of **free starter templates** for that product.
- Editor: text, fonts, shapes, image upload, the free clipart/template set, undo/redo. (Hide tenant-only / pro-only controls.)
- Export gated behind a one-field account create (§4).

Explicitly out of v1: multi-page beyond front/back, 3D preview (save for the in-product demo), pricing, checkout, payment, ordering. The free tool's job is *design → signup*, not *order*.

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4. The gate (where the funnel converts)

Let people **design freely with no friction** — gating too early kills the SEO/UX value. Gate only at the **moment of value capture**: export / download / save.

- Designing: 100% open, no login, anonymous local draft (reuse IndexedDB).
- On **Export / Download / Save**: show a single-field "Create a free account to download your design" wall (email + password, or Google). On success: deliver the file **and** persist the design to the new account.
- Post-signup CTA (soft, never blocking): *"Want to sell designs like this from your own print store? Start your free trial →"* → the store-trial onboarding.
- Carry the anonymous draft across the signup boundary so nothing is lost (the silent-drop rule applies: design in → design out).

Conversion path to instrument: `tool visit → design started → export attempted → account created → store trial started`.

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5. SEO surface

- **Target queries:** `free business card maker`, `free flyer maker`, `online [product] designer`, `[product] template free`. High volume; the gate converts a slice to product trials. (Stay off saturated head terms per the kit's guardrails.)
- **One indexable landing page per tool** with: H1 matching the query, a live "start designing" embed/CTA above the fold, the template gallery (each template a thumbnail with its own crawlable detail), a short "how it works", and a single soft CTA to the store trial.
- **Programmatic/template SEO:** generate a crawlable page per starter template (e.g. `/tools/business-card-maker/templates/minimal-bold`) — the Notion/Canva template-directory playbook. Seed from product/template data; keep thin pages out (only index templates with a real preview).
- Internal-link these pages from the relevant BOFU comparison pages and JTBD guides, and vice-versa.

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6. Analytics & attribution (build in from day one)

Per the metrics work, instrument server-side where possible and tag everything:

- UTM on every outbound link from a tool page to the trial.
- Events: `tool_page_view`, `design_started`, `template_selected`, `image_uploaded`, `export_attempted`, `account_created` (source=`free_tool:<product>`), `store_trial_started`.

- A single funnel report: tool → design → export → account → trial, sliced by tool (business-card vs flyer) and by source query/UTM.
- This is the data that tells you whether the free tool earns a place as a focus channel (CAC/Volume/Fit) or stays a background asset.

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7. Guardrails (house rules that apply)

- **Anonymous uploads:** route through a marketing/landlord upload path with **short-TTL auto-cleanup**; never into a tenant bucket. Store relative paths only.
- **No raw technical output:** loading/empty/error states required; plain-language messages; no UUIDs/slugs/engine type names on screen (a text layer is named by its text, an image by its filename — already the designer's standard).
- **Mobile:** the canvas must be usable (or gracefully degrade) at 375px; if full editing isn't viable on phone, offer template pick + text edit and prompt desktop for full design — never a broken canvas.
- **Abuse/cost control:** rate-limit anonymous exports and uploads; cap canvas size/upload size; the tool is a magnet, not free unlimited rendering.
- **Don't leak tenant features:** hide pro/tenant-only controls; the free tool is intentionally a subset.

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8. Build sequence (matches kit week 2–6 front-load sprint)

1. **Standalone anonymous entry** — render the existing canvas outside tenant context, with business-card dimensions + guides preset; anonymous local draft. *(De-risk the architecture first — this is the only genuinely new plumbing.)*
2. **Landing page #1** (`/tools/business-card-maker`) — indexable, live CTA, curated free templates.
3. **The export gate** — single-field account create on export; carry the draft across; post-signup trial CTA.
4. **Instrumentation** — events + UTM + the funnel report.
5. **Landing page #2** (flyer) — reuse everything; second product type.
6. **Template-detail pages** — programmatic SEO from the seeded template set.

Definition of done (v1): a stranger can land from Google on the business-card maker, design with no login, hit export, create an account, receive their file, see the "start your store trial" CTA — and every step shows up in the funnel report.

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9. What this is NOT

- Not a second product to maintain — it's a thin marketing skin over the existing `designer/`.
- Not an ordering/checkout flow — design→signup only.

- Not a place to ship the 3D preview or pricing engine — those stay as the *in-product* demo that rewards the trial.

Spec only. Grounded in the shipped `designer/` (Fabric.js) capabilities; the only net-new engineering is tenant-less anonymous mode, the indexable marketing pages, the export gate, and instrumentation. Sequenced to fit the execution kit's week 2–6 front-load sprint.

Local & Geo Marketing for Print-Flow-360: A Dual-Sided Playbook

Source: readme/research/marketing/LOCAL_GEO_MARKETING_AND_SEO_2026-06-16.md

IN SHORT — KEY TAKEAWAYS

This document is a two-part plan for Print-Flow-360. The first part explains how to find and sign up local print shops, one city at a time. The second part explains how to help those shops show up at the top of Google searches in their own town — and how building that help directly into the product makes us harder to replace.

The main parts explained simply:

- **The Google Map Pack** — When someone searches "print shop near me," Google shows a box of 3 local businesses with a map. Getting into that box (called the Map Pack) means more customers walking in and calling. This document explains exactly what makes Google pick a shop for that box.
- **Google Business Profile (GBP)** — A free Google listing every business can claim. It is the single biggest factor in local ranking (32% of the score). Getting it set up correctly — right category, accurate address, photos, hours — matters more than anything else.
- **Reviews** — The second biggest factor (20%, and rising fast). A shop with steady new reviews every week ranks higher and gets more clicks than one with no recent reviews. This document shows how to automate review requests after every order.
- **NAP consistency** — NAP means Name, Address, Phone. If these three things are written differently across Google, Yelp, Facebook, and other directories, Google trusts the business less. Everything must match exactly, everywhere.
- **Apple Business Connect** — Apple's version of Google Business Profile, free, and showing up on every iPhone. Almost no print shop has claimed it. Easy win.
- **Territory-first approach to signing up shops** — Instead of running national ads, the plan is to focus on one city at a time. Print shop owners in the same city know each other. One happy customer in a city convinces the next shop. The free offer is a quick check of the shop's current Google presence to open the conversation.
- **Print industry associations (PRINTING United Alliance, APAN)** — Two real national networks of print shops and regional associations. Partnering with them gives warm access to hundreds of shops without cold outreach.
- **9-step local SEO checklist** — A plain-English, step-by-step guide built into the product that walks a shop owner through everything: claiming their Google listing, picking the right category, getting listed on directories, asking for reviews, and more.
- **Built-in product features** — Schema code (invisible text that tells Google what the business does and where), auto-generated city-specific pages ("Business Cards in Chicago"), review-request emails after orders, and a Google listing connection. These make Print-Flow-360 stickier than a generic website builder.

What to do with this: Start with one city — reach out to shops using a free Google presence check as the opener. Then ship the LocalBusiness schema injection on storefronts and the review-request email on order completion. Those two product changes give every shop an instant SEO boost and become the clearest proof the platform is worth paying for.

TL;DR: Print shops are physical, location-bound businesses — which means local marketing is a double opportunity for Print-Flow-360. We can acquire shops *territory by territory* (founder-led local outreach + print associations + chambers) far more efficiently than spraying national ads, and we can hand every shop a **local-SEO playbook** so their Print-Flow-360 storefront ranks in Google's Map Pack. Building local-SEO scaffolding *into the product* (LocalBusiness schema, geo landing pages, Google Business Profile sync) turns "help me get found locally" into a sticky, hard-to-copy wedge. Start with one metro, get reference customers ranking, then repeat.

> **Why this matters for Print-Flow-360** Our buyers (non-technical local print shop owners) live and die by foot traffic and "near me" search. Their #1 unspoken question isn't "does this have a design studio?" — it's *"will this get me more orders?"* If our product visibly helps them win the Google Map Pack in their town, we're not selling software, we're selling **more local orders**. That reframes the entire pitch and gives us a moat the incumbents (Vistaprint, OnPrintShop) don't lead with. Both sides of this doc compound: shops that rank locally become our visible case studies, which fuels the next territory.

Part 0 — The local SEO mechanics you must understand first

You can't sell local-SEO help (or use it yourself) without knowing how Google actually ranks local results. The **Map Pack** (also called the "Local Pack" — the box of 3 businesses with a map that appears at the top of local searches) is governed by Google's three pillars, taught in every credible 2025–2026 source (Local Falcon, BrightLocal):

Pillar	Plain-language meaning	What the shop controls
Relevance	How well the business matches the search ("business cards near me")	Categories, business name, services, on-page keywords
Proximity (Distance)	How close the shop's physical address is to the searcher	Real verified address; you can't fake this
Prominence	How well-known/trusted the shop is	Reviews, citations, links, brand mentions

BrightLocal's 2026 Local Search Ranking Factors survey weights the Local Pack signals concretely — memorize these, they drive everything below:

- **Google Business Profile (GBP) — 32%** (the single biggest lever)
- **Reviews — 20%** (up from 16% in 2023 — *rising fast*)
- **On-page signals — 15%**
- Behavioral (clicks, calls) — 9% · Links — 8% · Citations — 6% · Social — 5%

Key facts to internalize:

- The **primary GBP category** is the #1 individual factor. Correct category choice = ~17% stronger visibility.

- **Reviews move clicks, not just rank:** a 4.5-star business gets ~28% more clicks than a 4.0-star one. A 0.1-star difference is material.
- **NAP consistency** = Name, Address, Phone identical across every directory. Inconsistency dilutes trust. Citations are "only becoming more important" as AI search (ChatGPT, Google AI Overviews) leans on structured data to verify businesses.
- **"Near me" intent is huge:** ~88% of mobile local searches lead to a call or visit within 24 hours.
- **Apple Business Connect** is the Apple-Maps equivalent of GBP — free, ~75–100M US users, default on every iPhone, feeds Siri. Most shops have *never claimed it*. Easy win.

PART 1 — How WE acquire local print shops (geo go-to-market)

The framework: Bullseye + territory concentration

Use the **Bullseye Framework** (from *Traction* by Gabriel Weinberg) — brainstorm channels, cheaply test the promising ones, then **double down on the one that works**. For an early-stage SaaS selling to non-technical local owners, the winning channel is almost never paid national ads. It's **founder-led, geographically concentrated outreach**. As GTM convention holds: *your first ~10 customers come from founder-led sales, not a funnel.*

Why concentrate by territory (one metro at a time)?

- Density creates word-of-mouth. Print shop owners in a city know each other and the local print community.
- Reference customers are local and visit-able — you can do in-person demos and screenshots of *their town's* Map Pack.
- Local case studies ("3 shops in [City] now rank #1 for 'business cards [City]'") are devastatingly persuasive to the 4th shop.

Concrete acquisition tactics (do these this quarter)

1. Founder-led local outreach in ONE target metro. Pick a mid-size US metro with 20–60 independent print shops (avoid markets Vistaprint-saturated; target *commercial/local* shops, not nationals). Build the list from Google Maps + Yelp ("print shop," "sign shop," "copy center" within the metro). Walk in or call. The pitch is order-volume, not features: *"I help local print shops in [City] take orders online and show up on Google Maps — can I show you what your competitor's online store could look like?"*

2. Print industry associations. Real, named bodies to engage:

- **PRINTING United Alliance** (printing.org) — largest US graphic-arts trade association (SGIA + PIA merger); runs the annual **PRINTING United Expo**. Sponsor/exhibit or attend to meet owners.
- **APAN (Americas Printing Association Network)** — ~4,100 commercial print companies across **14 regional, not-for-profit associations**. *This is the territory map handed to you.* Partner regionally — each regional association is a warm channel into a metro's shops.

3. Local Chambers of Commerce + BNI. Print shops are classic chamber members. Join your target metro's chamber; sponsor a "get your business online" workshop. This is also a referral engine — chamber members *are* the shops' end-customers (local businesses ordering cards/banners).

4. Geo-targeted ads as a *test*, not the engine. Per 2025 geo-targeting guidance: **Meta (Facebook/Instagram) supports radius targeting** — draw a 5–15 mile circle around a metro and target small-business-owner interests + the "print"/"sign shop owner" job titles. **LinkedIn lacks radius targeting** but lets you target by company industry ("Printing") + geography region — good for B2B owner reach. Budget small ($300–500) purely to validate messaging; the *signal* (replies, demo bookings) tells you what resonates before you scale spend.

5. The "we'll get you ranking" lead magnet. Offer every prospect a **free 5-minute Map Pack audit** of their current Google presence (most have an unclaimed/messy GBP). This opens the door and *demonstrates* the local-SEO value we deliver in Part 2.

Acquisition metrics to track per territory

- Shops contacted → demos booked → trials started → paid (track the funnel ratios; aim to systematize once you hit ~10 paying customers in metro #1).
- Cost per paying shop (should be near-zero in founder-led phase).
- Time-to-first-order for each new shop's storefront (our North Star — proves the product works).

PART 2 — The Local SEO Playbook we hand to our shops (the product wedge)

This is the strategic heart. **Turn local-SEO help into a feature and a sales argument.** The pitch becomes: *"Other website builders give you a store. Print-Flow-360 gets you found."*

A) The 9-step playbook every shop should follow (we ship this as guided onboarding)

Write this as plain-language, in-app checklist steps — non-technical owners, no jargon:

1. **Claim & verify your Google Business Profile.** (32% of ranking — the biggest lever.)
2. **Pick the right primary category** — "Print shop," "Sign shop," "Commercial printer" etc. (#1 individual factor). Add secondary categories.
3. **Lock your NAP** — exact Name/Address/Phone, identical everywhere. We auto-fill this from their store profile.
4. **Claim Apple Business Connect** — free, feeds Apple Maps + Siri, almost nobody does it. Easy edge.
5. **Get on the core directories:** Yelp, Bing Places, Facebook, BBB, Yellow Pages, plus print-niche directories — all with identical NAP. (Citations = 6% and rising for AI search.)
6. **Run a review engine** — ask every happy customer at pickup; aim for steady *velocity* (a few per week beats 50 then silence). Encourage reviews that mention the *service + city* ("great business cards in [City]"). Respond to all reviews. Never buy/incentivize — Google's 2024+ enforcement removes fakes and can penalize.

7. **Publish geo landing pages** — one page per service/city they serve (“Business Cards in [City]”, “Vinyl Banners [Neighborhood]”).
8. **Add LocalBusiness schema** to the storefront (structured data so Google/AI know address, hours, services).
9. **Post offers + photos** on GBP regularly; keep hours accurate (“openness” is now a ranking filter).

B) Product implications — bake the playbook into Print-Flow-360 (this is the moat)

These make us stickier than a generic Shopify/website builder and directly serve our §0 UX standard (non-technical, guided, plain-language):

Feature to build	Why it wins	Notes for our stack
LocalBusiness / GeoCoordinates schema auto-injected	Storefront ships SEO-ready; AI search (Google AI Overviews, ChatGPT) can cite it.	SSR-inject JSON-LD from store profile (address, hours, services). Frontstore is SSR Nuxt — render in `<head>`, one schema per location.
Geo landing-page generator	“Business Cards in [City]” pages from existing catalog + service area.	A CMS block / templated page driven by the shop’s products × service-area list. Reuse the block-renderer pattern.
Google Business Profile connection	One-click sync of NAP, hours, products → GBP; surfaces review count in admin.	OAuth to GBP API; an *integration* per our integrations architecture. Until built, guide them (per §0: never a dead link — show “Connect your Google listing → Settings”).
Review-request automation	Order-complete → email/SMS asking for a Google review. Reviews = 20% of rank.	Hook the order-lifecycle (job marked picked-up/complete) → notification event. We already have a notifications/queue spine.
NAP-consistency dashboard	Shows where their listing is inconsistent; a recurring “your local presence” health score.	Plain-language: “Your phone number doesn’t match on Yelp — fix it” + recovery action.
“Local presence” onboarding checklist	The 9 steps above as a guided, non-technical wizard.	Matches our onboarding/go-live checklist philosophy; ties to the North Star (store live + first local order).

Marketing implication: lead every demo, landing page, and pricing tier with **“Get found on Google Maps”**, not “design studio” or “pricing engine.” Those are *how*; local orders are *why*. This is also a clean **April Dunford positioning** anchor — our differentiated value vs. Shopify (no local-SEO scaffolding) and Vistaprint (takes the shop’s customers) is: *the simplest way for a local print shop to sell online AND get found in its own town.*

Prioritized action checklist (executable now)

Acquisition (us):

1. [ ] Pick metro #1 (20–60 independent shops, not Vistaprint-saturated). Build the list from Google Maps/Yelp.
2. [ ] Start founder-led outreach with the **free Map Pack audit** as the door-opener.
3. [ ] Join the metro's **Chamber of Commerce** + identify the **APAN regional association** covering it.
4. [ ] Put PRINTING United Expo on the calendar; plan a presence.
5. [ ] Run a $300–500 Meta radius-targeted test ad to validate messaging (not to scale).

Product wedge (shops): 6. [ ] Ship **LocalBusiness schema** auto-injection on every storefront (highest leverage, lowest effort). 7. [ ] Build the **9-step "Local Presence" onboarding checklist** in admin. 8. [ ] Ship **review-request automation** off the order-complete event. 9. [ ] Spec the **GBP connection** integration; until live, add the guided "Connect your Google listing" prompt. 10. [ ] Build the **geo landing-page generator** (service × city) as a CMS block.

KPIs to track

Our acquisition: shops contacted → demos → trials → paid (per metro); CAC per shop; territory penetration %; referral rate within a metro. **Shop success (our North Star, proves product):** time-to-first-online-order; shops appearing in their local Map Pack; avg. review count & star rating per shop; GBP-connected %; geo-pages published per shop.

Common mistakes / anti-patterns

- **Going national too early.** Spray-and-pray ads to scattered shops kills word-of-mouth density. Concentrate.
- **Leading with features.** "Fabric.js design studio" means nothing to a shop owner. Lead with *more local orders / Google Maps*.
- **Buying or incentivizing reviews.** Google's 2024+ enforcement deletes fakes and can penalize. Always organic, always steady velocity, never a burst.
- **Inconsistent NAP.** The #1 silent local-SEO killer. Our auto-fill from store profile must guarantee one source of truth.
- **Ignoring Apple Business Connect.** Free, ~90% of iPhone users on Apple Maps, almost nobody claims it — a cheap differentiator we can hand shops.
- **Schema/geo pages as duplicate content.** Each geo page and each location's schema must be genuinely unique (unique NAP, unique copy) or Google ignores/penalizes them.
- **Dead integration states** (violates our §0): never show "No Google listing found." Always explain + link to setup.
- **Treating local SEO as a one-time setup.** Rankings need ongoing reviews, posts, accurate hours ("openness" is now a filter) — which is exactly why automating it *in-product* makes us sticky.

Further reading / sources

- BrightLocal — *Google's Local Algorithm & Local Ranking Factors (2026 survey, with weights)*: https://www.brightlocal.com/learn/google-local-algorithm-and-ranking-factors/
- Local Falcon — *The Big 3 Local Ranking Factors*: https://www.localfalcon.com/blog/what-are-the-most-important-local-search-ranking-factors
- BizIQ — *Local SEO Statistics 2026 (GBP weight, review click data)*: https://biziq.com/blog/local-seo-statistics/
- Local Falcon — *Apple Maps SEO with Apple Business Connect (2025)*: https://www.localfalcon.com/blog/tips-for-ranking-higher-on-apple-maps
- Search Engine Journal — *How to Use Schema for Local SEO (LocalBusiness structured data)*: https://www.searchenginejournal.com/how-to-use-schema-for-local-seo-a-complete-guide/294973/
- W3Era — *Top Local SEO Citation Sites USA 2026*: https://www.w3era.com/blog/local-seo/local-seo-citations-usa/
- PRINTING United Alliance (industry association): https://www.printing.org/
- UPrinting — *Printing Industry Associations in the US (APAN regional network)*: https://www.uprinting.com/printing-101/printing-industry-associations-in-the-us.html
- Birdeye — *Google Business Profile / Review guidelines 2025*: https://birdeye.com/blog/google-business-profile-guidelines-2025/
- Improvado — *Geo-Targeting Advertising 2026 Guide (Meta radius vs LinkedIn)*: https://improvado.io/blog/geotargeting-advertising
- DesignRevision — *B2B SaaS Go-to-Market Playbook 2026 (founder-led sales)*: https://designrevision.com/blog/b2b-saas-go-to-market-strategy

Marketplace & Directory Presence Strategy for Print-Flow-360

Source: readme/research/marketing/MARKETPLACE_AND_DIRECTORY_PRESENCE_2026-06-16.md

IN SHORT — KEY TAKEAWAYS

When a print shop owner decides to buy software, they don't go to your website first — they Google "best web-to-print software" and land on comparison pages like Capterra or G2. This document explains exactly where those buyers look, how to get listed (mostly free), and how to collect reviews the right way so your listing rises to the top. If you're not on these pages, you're invisible before the conversation even starts.

The main parts explained simply:

- **The three types of discovery sites** — There are review sites (like Capterra and G2, where buyers compare software), app marketplaces (like the Shopify App Store, built into other platforms), and industry directories (print trade sites and "best web-to-print" blog lists). Each attracts a different kind of buyer, and review sites carry the highest intent — people are ready to choose.
- **The 2026 merger that changes everything** — G2 bought Capterra, GetApp, and Software Advice in early 2026. Because Capterra, GetApp, and Software Advice already shared one backend, one review you collect shows up on all three automatically. You now only need to manage two relationships instead of five. This is very good news for a small team.
- **How rankings work — reviews, not money** — Your position in a category is driven by how many reviews you have, how recent they are, and your star rating. Paying money buys you an ad slot, not a better score. Get reviews first; worry about paid ads later.
- **The legal rules around reviews (FTC)** — A US law that took effect in October 2024 makes fake reviews and "bribed" positive reviews illegal, with fines up to $51,000 per case. You can offer a small gift card to anyone who leaves a review, but you cannot make it depend on them giving you 5 stars. Ask all customers, not just happy ones.
- **Whether to build a Shopify app** — The document recommends staying standalone for now. Your product *is* the storefront — building inside Shopify means giving away your main advantage. A lightweight WooCommerce connection is a better first step for shops already on WordPress.
- **What to do first, second, and third** — Claim your free Capterra profile this week (it spreads to GetApp and Software Advice automatically), then claim G2, then GoodFirms and SourceForge. These are all free and cover most of where your buyers search.
- **The review collection engine** — Ask every customer at a happy moment (their first online order, going live), offer the same small thank-you to all, and send a direct link so they don't have to figure out where to go. Aim for two to four new reviews every month — a steady stream beats a one-time push.
- **Common traps to avoid** — Don't pay for ads before you have reviews. Don't list yourself under "Ecommerce" — list under "Web-to-Print" specifically. Don't ignore negative reviews; a calm, polite reply is free trust-building.

What to do with this: Claim your free Capterra listing this week and write a simple one-page process for asking customers for reviews — same small reward for everyone, direct link, no strings attached. That one habit, done consistently, is the highest-leverage move in this entire document.

TL;DR: Software review sites (G2, Capterra) and a handful of print-industry listicles are where your buyers — non-technical print shop owners — actually compare web-to-print tools before buying. The good news: getting *listed* is free almost everywhere, the algorithms reward reviews you can generate yourself, and a 2026 industry consolidation (G2 bought Capterra) means one focused effort now covers most of the discovery surface. The single highest-leverage move is a disciplined, FTC-compliant review-generation engine pointed at Capterra/GetApp first, plus getting written into the "best web-to-print software" comparison posts that rank for your category.

> **Why this matters for Print-Flow-360** Your buyer is a local shop owner who does not read developer docs and does not trust a vendor's own website. When they decide to "sell online," they Google *"best web-to-print software"* or *"print shop ecommerce software"* and land on a comparison listicle or a Capterra category page. If Print-Flow-360 isn't on those pages — with reviews and a clear "simplest for non-technical shops" hook — you are invisible at the exact moment of consideration. Directories are not vanity; they are the buyer's shortlist. Being absent = being eliminated before the demo.

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1. The landscape, decoded (which sites, how they actually work)

There are three distinct surfaces, and they convert differently:

Surface	Examples	What it is	Buyer intent
B2B software review sites	G2, Capterra, GetApp, Software Advice, TrustRadius, SourceForge, GoodFirms	"Yelp for software" — category pages, star ratings, badges	High — actively comparing tools
App marketplaces	Shopify App Store, WordPress/WooCommerce, Wix, BigCommerce	Distribution *inside* another platform	Medium — already committed to a host platform
Industry directories & listicles	PRINTING United Alliance directory, "best web-to-print software" blog posts, GoodFirms print category	Trade-specific discovery and editorial roundups	Mixed — but hyper-relevant audience

Critical 2026 development: In February 2026, **G2 acquired Capterra, GetApp, and Software Advice from Gartner** (~$110M). Capterra/GetApp/Software Advice already shared one backend — *one review you collect appears on all three.* Now the entire dominant discovery layer sits under one roof. Practically, this means you manage **two vendor relationships, not five**: the Gartner-legacy cluster (Capterra/GetApp/Software Advice) and G2.

How rankings & badges work (the part vendors get wrong)

- **G2 ranking formula:** `(Market Satisfaction + Market Presence) ÷ 2`. Satisfaction comes from review volume + recency + ratings; Presence comes from company size, web mentions, social following. The famous **Grid** plots these two axes. Badges = "Leader," "High Performer," "Momentum."

- **G2 badge catch (changed Summer 2025):** You now need a **paid plan ($2,999+/yr)** to *publicly display* Grid/Momentum/Index/Award badges. The free **“Users Love Us”** badge (10+ reviews) is still free.
- **Capterra/GetApp: Listing is free, responding to reviews is free, earning and displaying badges is free.** Their paid layer is a **pay-per-click (PPC) auction** — minimum ~$2/click, ~$500/mo minimum budget, second-price auction; sponsored profiles rank above free ones. CPC varies wildly by category competitiveness.
- **Pay-to-play vs organic:** On all of them, *reviews and basic listing are organic and free.* Paid money buys **placement/ads**, not ratings. You cannot buy a better score — only more visibility for the score you’ve earned.

Opinionated take for you: Do **not** pay for badges or PPC yet. At early stage your money is better spent generating reviews (which lift you organically) than renting a top-3 slot in a category you can’t yet convert from.

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2. The legal guardrails you must not cross (FTC + platform rules)

This is non-negotiable and recently got teeth. The **FTC Final Rule on fake reviews took effect October 21, 2024**, with civil penalties up to **$51,744 per violation**. It bans:

- Fake/AI-fabricated reviews or reviews attributed to people who didn’t write them.
- **Offering any incentive in exchange for a *specific sentiment*** (positive *or* negative) — stated or implied.
- “Review gating” — selectively soliciting/displaying only happy customers and suppressing unhappy ones.

Platform rules (G2, Capterra) mirror this. **What you CAN do:**

- ✅ Incentivize the *act* of reviewing (e.g., a $25–50 gift card — the documented B2B sweet spot), offered to **all** customers **regardless of what they say**.
- ✅ Clearly disclose any incentive; G2 labels incentivized reviews.
- ✅ Ask a **representative** slice of customers — not just the ones who just renewed or love you.

What you must NEVER do: condition rewards on 5 stars, ask “leave us a 5-star review,” only email happy customers, or filter out negatives. For a tiny early-stage vendor, one FTC complaint is existential. Build the program clean from day one.

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3. Should you build a Shopify/WooCommerce app, or stay standalone?

This is your biggest strategic fork, so be deliberate.

The case for a Shopify app: Shopify is ~30% of U.S. ecommerce, 6,000+ apps, staff actively feature good ones. Revenue terms are now generous — **100% of your first $1M/yr, then 85%** (2.9% processing fee), and a **one-time $19 partner fee**.

The case against, for *you* specifically:

- Your positioning is **"the simplest way for a non-technical shop to sell online *without hiring a developer.*"** A Shopify app assumes the shop *already runs Shopify* — i.e., already built an online store. That's a different, more technical buyer than your ICP. You'd be selling a *bolt-on* to people who don't have the store yet.
- Print-Flow-360 *is* the storefront (catalog + pricing engine + design studio + CMS themes). Wrapping that as a Shopify app means duplicating/cannibalizing your own core. Web-to-print on Shopify means surrendering the storefront — your differentiator — to Shopify and integrating as a personalizer/pricing add-on.
- Note your competitors split exactly this way: **OnPrintShop is "built for reach"** (300+ integrations incl. Shopify/WooCommerce/Magento), **DesignNBuy is "built for depth"** as the one-stop platform. You are a depth/all-in-one player. Don't dilute that.

Recommendation: Stay standalone as the primary motion. Treat a Shopify *integration* (not a full app-store app) as a **Phase 2 lead-gen channel** — a lightweight "Add print products to your existing Shopify store" connector that gets you a free Shopify App Store listing for SEO/discovery, while your real product remains the standalone storefront. **WooCommerce** is the more natural integration to do *first* (your non-technical-but-already-on-WordPress shops are a real segment, and the listing is free/SEO-valuable). Build the standalone reputation first; integrations are channel #4, not #1.

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4. Prioritized rollout — what to do, in what order

Tier 1 — Do this month (free, high intent)

1. **Capterra + GetApp + Software Advice (one claim, three listings).** Claim/create your vendor profile in the Gartner-legacy dashboard. Target category: **Web-to-Print Software** (it exists on Capterra/Software Advice/GoodFirms) plus secondary **Ecommerce / Print Estimating**. Effort: ~1 day to build a great profile (screenshots, the design-studio demo, plain-language feature list, pricing). Cost: $0. *Why first:* free, print-specific category exists, one effort = three sites, highest buyer intent.
2. **G2 profile (free tier).** Claim it, complete it, chase the free **"Users Love Us"** badge at 10 reviews. Cost: $0. Skip the paid badge plan for now.
3. **GoodFirms + SourceForge web-to-print listings.** Both have real **web-to-print software** categories and rank in Google for your terms. Free. ~2 hours each.

Tier 2 — Next 60 days (industry-specific & editorial)

4. **PRINTING United Alliance directory** (directory.printing.org). North America's largest printing association, 20,000+ members; their directory lets buyers find suppliers. Requires **membership** (corporate Supplier tier). Cost: membership dues (mid-hundreds to low-thousands/yr) — worth it for the credibility halo + Expo access + association co-marketing, not just the listing.

5. **Get written into the "best web-to-print software" listicles.** These rank #1 for your exact buyer query. Concrete targets identified in research: DesignNBuy's "11 Best Web-To-Print Softwares Compared," Wbcom Designs' "7 Best Web To Print Software," SaaS-Space's "Best 5 Web to Print Software for Print Shops," Danetsoft's "OnPrintShop Alternatives," and Software Advice's web-to-print alternatives page. Outreach: email each author, offer a free account + a crisp 2-line positioning blurb ("the simplest web-to-print for non-technical shops"). Some are competitor-owned (DesignNBuy) — skip those; prioritize neutral/affiliate ones.

Tier 3 — Phase 2 (paid / integration plays, only once reviews are flowing)

6. **WooCommerce.org plugin listing** — free, SEO-valuable, natural fit for WordPress shops.
7. **Shopify App Store** *integration* listing — distribution + discovery, not your core motion (see §3).
8. **Capterra PPC / G2 paid** — only after you can prove demo → close conversion. Until then it's burning cash.

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5. The review-generation playbook (your real growth engine)

Reviews are the flywheel: more reviews → higher organic rank → more leads → more reviews. Run it like a process, not a one-off ask.

The mechanics:

1. **Trigger on a happy moment, ask everyone.** Send the review request after a real success signal (shop goes live, first online order placed, 30-day mark) — but send to *every* customer who hits that trigger, not a cherry-picked few (FTC representativeness).
2. **Offer the same small thank-you to all** — e.g., a $25 gift card *for leaving a review of any kind*. State it plainly; never tie it to stars.
3. **Make it stupidly easy for non-technical owners.** Don't say "go to Capterra and authenticate." Send a direct deep-link to your Capterra review form, pre-explain the 2-minute steps with a screenshot, and offer to hop on a call to do it together. Your ICP *will* abandon a clunky review flow.
4. **Seed Capterra first, then G2.** Capterra reviews fan out to GetApp/Software Advice automatically — best ROI per ask.
5. **Respond to every review, especially negatives,** in plain language. Public, gracious responses are a ranking and trust signal.
6. **Cadence target:** aim for **2–4 fresh reviews/month**. Recency is weighted; a steady drip beats a one-time blast and keeps "Momentum" alive.

Anti-pattern to kill on sight: the "review gating" funnel some SaaS tools sell ("ask happy customers for public reviews, route unhappy ones to private feedback"). That is now explicitly **illegal under the FTC rule.** Don't use any tool that does it.

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6. Metrics / KPIs to track

Metric	Why	Early target
Total reviews per site (Capterra, G2)	Drives organic rank & "Users Love Us" badge	10 on Capterra & G2 in 90 days
Review recency (reviews in last 90 days)	Recency is weighted in ranking	≥6 rolling
Average star rating	Trust signal on the shortlist	≥4.5
Category rank position (organic)	Visibility at point of decision	Top half of Web-to-Print category
Referral traffic & demos from each directory	Proves which surface actually converts	Track per-source in analytics
Listicle inclusions ("best web-to-print" posts)	Owns the high-intent SEO query	3 neutral posts in 6 months
Review-request → completed-review rate	Health of the gen engine	≥15%

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7. Common mistakes / anti-patterns

- **Paying for ads before you have reviews.** A sponsored top-3 slot with 1 review and a 3.8 rating converts worse than an organic #6 with 20 reviews at 4.7. Earn the reputation first.
- **Buying badges to look bigger.** The free Capterra badges and G2 "Users Love Us" are enough at your stage; the $2,999+ G2 badge plan is premature.
- **Cherry-picking who you ask** (renewals only, fans only). Illegal *and* it produces a fake-looking all-5-star profile buyers distrust.
- **Listing in the wrong category.** Get into **Web-to-Print** specifically, not just generic "Ecommerce" where you drown next to Shopify.
- **Treating Shopify App Store as the main bet.** It contradicts your "no developer needed, we *are* the storefront" positioning. Standalone first.
- **Ignoring negative reviews.** Silence reads as guilt; a calm public reply is free reputation insurance.
- **Generic profiles.** Your design-studio demo and "for non-technical shops" angle are your edge — lead the profile with them, not a feature dump.

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8. This-week action checklist

- [ ] Claim and fully build the **Capterra vendor profile** in the Web-to-Print category (cascades to GetApp + Software Advice).

- [ ] Claim and complete the **G2 profile**; set goal of 10 reviews for the free badge.
- [ ] Create **GoodFirms** and **SourceForge** web-to-print listings.
- [ ] Write a one-page, FTC-clean **review-request SOP** (trigger, same-incentive-to-all, deep-link + screenshot, no sentiment conditions).
- [ ] Identify the first **10 happiest live customers** who hit a success trigger and send the compliant ask.
- [ ] Draft a **2-line positioning blurb** + free-account offer and email **3 neutral "best web-to-print" listicle authors**.
- [ ] Price out **PRINTING United Alliance** corporate membership for the directory + association credibility.

Further reading / sources

- G2 acquires Capterra/GetApp/Software Advice (Feb 2026): https://company.g2.com/news/g2-acquires-capterra-software-advice-getapp and https://www.prnewswire.com/news-releases/g2-to-acquire-capterra-software-advice-and-getapp-from-gartner-302673901.html
- G2 ranking, badges & paid-plan changes: https://blastra.io/guides/how-to-get-ranked-on-g2/ and https://blastra.io/guides/how-to-earn-g2-badges/
- Capterra vendor pricing (free vs PPC): https://blastra.io/blog/g2-capterra-vendor-pricing-compared/ and https://www.capterra.com/glossary/cpc-cost-per-click/
- G2 Community Guidelines (incentivized reviews): https://legal.g2.com/community-guidelines
- FTC Final Rule banning fake reviews (effective Oct 21, 2024): https://www.ftc.gov/news-events/news/press-releases/2024/08/federal-trade-commission-announces-final-rule-banning-fake-reviews-testimonials and https://perkinscoie.com/insights/update/ftc-finalizes-rule-banning-fake-reviews-and-testimonials
- FTC incentivized-review compliance for vendors: https://solutions.trustradius.com/vendor/b2b-reviews/ftc-incentivized-review-guidelines-welcome-to-the-party/ and https://learn.g2.com/ftc-guidelines-for-reviews
- Shopify App Store revenue share & distribution: https://shopify.dev/docs/apps/launch/distribution/revenue-share and https://www.preetamnath.com/blog/shopify-micro-saas
- Web-to-print competitive comparisons (OnPrintShop "reach" vs DesignNBuy "depth"): https://www.designnbuy.com/blog/best-web-to-print-softwares-compared/ and https://saas-space.com/best-5-web-to-print-software-for-print-shops-in-2025/
- Web-to-print directory categories: https://www.goodfirms.co/web-to-print-software/ and https://www.softwareadvice.com/web-to-print/web-to-print-shop-profile/alternatives/
- PRINTING United Alliance directory & membership: https://directory.printing.org/ and https://www.printing.org/membership

Positioning → Messaging → Branding: The Cascade for Print-Flow-360

Source: readme/research/marketing/POSITIONING_MESSAGING_BRANDING_2026-06-16.md

IN SHORT — KEY TAKEAWAYS

This document explains how to decide what your business stands for, how to talk about it, and how to make it look and feel consistent — so that every page, email, and conversation tells the same story. It matters because print software is crowded, and if you sound like everyone else, store owners will pick whoever they already know.

The main parts explained simply:

- **Positioning** — This is the private decision you make first: who is the product for, and why should they pick it over anything else? For Print-Flow-360, the answer is: "local print shops that want to sell online but don't have a developer." You decide this once and write it down. Everything else flows from it.
- **Messaging** — These are the actual words you put on your website, emails, and demos. The document suggests a simple structure: one headline that sums up the whole benefit ("Your print shop online by the weekend — no developer needed"), three core ideas a buyer should remember, and real proof under each one (a video, a quote, a number).
- **Branding** — This is how you look and sound: your colors, your writing style, and the personality behind every word. The recommendation is to sound like a helpful neighbor, not a tech company — short sentences, plain words, no jargon. The document uses Mailchimp as the model.
- **The "cascade" — why order matters** — Positioning must come first. If you skip it and jump straight to writing slogans, you will debate taglines forever because there is no decision underneath them. Once positioning is set, the words and the look follow naturally.
- **What happens when you change direction** — If you later discover a better target customer (say, sign shops instead of general print shops), the document shows exactly how that one change ripples into your headlines, your proof points, your product images, and even your demo script. Change the top, everything below updates.
- **Common traps** — The biggest ones: writing feature lists instead of outcomes ("Fabric.js studio" vs. "your customers design it themselves"), using business-speak that scares a non-technical buyer, and letting the website sound friendly while the product shows error codes and UUIDs.

What to do with this: Start by writing down one clear sentence about who Print-Flow-360 is for and why they should choose it over doing nothing or using Vistaprint. Pin that sentence somewhere visible. Then rewrite your homepage so every section answers that same question.

TL;DR: Positioning is the *strategic decision* about who you're for and why you win (internal, foundational). Messaging is the *words you say* to express that decision externally. Branding is how you *look, sound, and feel* while saying it. They nest — positioning sets the rules, messaging operationalizes them, branding dresses them — and a change at the top ripples all the way down. Below I run April Dunford's positioning exercise on Print-Flow-360, derive a concrete messaging hierarchy, and define brand attributes for a "trustworthy-but-simple" tool aimed at non-technical shop owners.

> **Why this matters for Print-Flow-360:** You are early-stage in a crowded market (OnPrintShop, DesignNBuy, Pressero, Printavo, plus Vistaprint and Shopify+Canva from the side). Your competitors' own users complain that the software is hard for "new admins" and "individual clients" to set up. That is a *positioning gap you can own.* But you can only own it if positioning, messaging, and brand all point at the same idea — "the web-to-print platform a non-technical shop owner can run alone." Get the cascade right and every landing page, email, and demo reinforces one story. Get it wrong and you sound like everyone else, competing on feature lists you'll lose to incumbents.

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1. The three layers, clearly defined

These three words get used interchangeably and that's the root of most fuzzy marketing. They are different jobs.

Layer	What it is	Audience	Output
Positioning	The strategic context you choose so customers instantly "get" what you are and why you're the obvious choice.	Internal (your team). It's a *decision*, not a slogan.	A one-page positioning statement
Messaging	The actual words that translate positioning into claims people read and hear.	External (prospects).	A value prop + 3 pillars + proof points ("messaging house")
Branding	The identity — visual + verbal — that makes the whole thing recognizable and trustworthy.	External (everyone).	Voice/tone rules, logo, color, type, personality

The cascade (and why order matters): Positioning is upstream of everything. Messaging *expresses* positioning; branding *clothes* the messaging. You cannot write good copy or design a good logo until you've decided your position. As the practitioners put it: positioning is the strategic decision (who you serve, what market, what makes you different); the messaging house translates it into language; brand makes it feel a certain way. Do them out of order and you get a pretty website that says nothing distinctive.

> **The cheap mistake to avoid:** founders skip positioning, jump to messaging ("let's write the homepage"), and end up debating taglines forever because there's no foundation underneath. Decide the position first; the words get easy.

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2. April Dunford's positioning exercise, run for Print-Flow-360

Dunford's *Obviously Awesome* framework has **five (+1) components**, worked in a specific order — start from competitive alternatives, because that's how customers actually decide. Here are concrete candidate answers for Print-Flow-360. Treat these as a first draft to validate against real customer interviews.

2.1 Competitive alternatives — *what would they do if you didn't exist?*

Not just "other web-to-print vendors." What a small shop owner *actually* does today:

- **Do nothing** — take orders by phone, email, and walk-in; email PDFs back and forth (the real #1 competitor: the status quo).
- **Vistaprint / Gelato-style POD** — send their own customers *away* to a giant, losing the relationship and margin.
- **Shopify + Canva + manual quoting** — a general store that can't do live print pricing or in-browser design.
- **Heavyweight web-to-print platforms** (OnPrintShop, DesignNBuy, Pressero/Aleyant, Infigo) — powerful, but reviewers flag them as hard for "new admins" to set up, with "less friendly" backend/quoting and expensive integrations. Often need a developer or a paid implementation.

2.2 Unique attributes — *what do you have that the alternatives don't?*

(Capabilities, stated as facts — not benefits yet.)

- Live print-pricing engine + embedded Fabric.js design studio + order/print-job lifecycle, **bundled in one product** (vs. stitching Shopify + a design tool + manual quotes).
- **Designed for non-technical owners**: navigate-by-intuition UI, plain-language labels, mandatory loading/empty/error states, guided onboarding — no developer or implementation consultant required.
- Multi-tenant SaaS storefront the shop **owns** (their brand, their customers) — not a marketplace that takes the customer.
- Built-in **B2B accounts** (corporate ordering, departments, pay-on-account) usually reserved for enterprise tiers.
- CMS-driven themes — one brand color rebrands the whole storefront.

2.3 Value (+ proof) — *what do those attributes let the customer do that they care about?*

Unique attribute	Value to a shop owner	Proof candidate
One bundled platform	Sell online without hiring anyone or wiring 3 tools together	“Go live in a weekend” onboarding video
Built for non-technical users	Run it yourself; no implementation fee, no IT	Side-by-side setup-time demo vs. incumbent
Owned storefront + customers	Keep the customer relationship and the margin Vistaprint takes	Customer story / margin math
Live pricing + design studio	Customers self-serve and self-design → fewer email back-and-forths	Time-saved testimonial

2.4 Best-fit customers — *who cares the most, fastest?*

- Small/independent **local print, sign, and copy shops** (a few staff, no dev, no IT).
- Owner-operators who are **losing business to Vistaprint** and to younger online-savvy competitors.
- Shops that already have local/B2B accounts they want to put online.
- **Anti-persona (say it out loud):** large trade printers needing deep MIS/automation integrations — that’s the incumbents’ game; chasing it makes you complicated, which kills your whole story.

2.5 Market category — *the context you want to be evaluated in*

This is the highest-leverage choice. Options:

- “Web-to-print software” — accurate, but lumps you with the heavyweights you’ll lose a feature-war to.
- **“Web-to-print for non-technical shops” / “the easiest way for a local print shop to sell online without a developer”** — a category frame *you can own*, where “simple” is a strength, not a gap.

Recommendation: Claim the second. Frame the category around *the buyer’s intuition and independence*, not feature depth.

2.6 The assembled positioning statement (internal)

> For independent local print, sign, and copy shops that want to sell online but don’t have a developer or IT, **Print-Flow-360 is the web-to-print platform you can set up and run yourself** — your own branded storefront with live pricing and an in-browser design studio, so your customers order and design online while you keep the relationship and the margin. Unlike heavyweight platforms that need a consultant, or Vistaprint that takes your customer, Print-Flow-360 is built for shop owners, not engineers.

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3. From positioning → the messaging hierarchy (the "messaging house")

The messaging house has three tiers: a **roof** (core value prop), **three pillars** (the beliefs you want held — three because that's what a buyer can hold in memory), and a **foundation** of proof points. Pillars are *outcomes*, never features.

Roof — core value proposition

Format: *We help [audience] [achieve outcome] by [differentiated approach].*

> **Print-Flow-360 helps local print shops sell and take orders online — set up by the owner, no developer needed.**

(Public homepage form: *"Your print shop, online by the weekend. No developer required."*)

The three pillars

Pillar	The belief (buyer-facing line)	Why it's an outcome, not a feature
1. You can do this yourself	"If you can run your shop, you can run this. No code, no consultant, no IT."	Speaks to the fear that online = needing a developer
2. One tool, the whole job	"Catalog, live pricing, online design, orders, and B2B accounts — in one place."	Outcome = stop duct-taping Shopify + Canva + email quotes
3. Your store, your customers	"A storefront branded as *you* — you keep the customer and the margin."	Outcome = independence from Vistaprint/marketplaces

Foundation — proof points (map ≥2 to each pillar)

- **Pillar 1:** guided onboarding + "go live in a weekend" walkthrough video; setup-time demo vs. an incumbent; "no implementation fee" badge.
- **Pillar 2:** product tour showing live pricing → design studio → order in one flow; B2B accounts screenshot.
- **Pillar 3:** before/after margin math vs. sending customers to Vistaprint; owner testimonial; one-color rebrand demo.

> As you get real customers, replace founder-asserted proof with the four hard types: **quantitative data, named customer quotes, third-party validation (reviews/awards), and mechanism explanations.** Mine the exact words from win/loss and sales calls — buyers' language outperforms yours.

4. From messaging → brand attributes & voice

Brand is the *feel* that carries the message. For a non-technical, slightly-anxious buyer, the right move is counterintuitive: simplifying voice from “premium/sophisticated” to “honest/helpful” raises trust and conversion (one documented case: +28% conversion, because plain language reduces purchase hesitation). The model here is **Mailchimp** — “plainspoken, genuine, a bit dry-humored” — which made software feel safe for small-business owners.

Brand attributes (pick 4-5, make them tradeoffs)

- **Plainspoken** — we explain in shop-owner words, never developer words.
- **Reassuring** — we remove the fear of “I’m not technical enough.”
- **Capable, not flashy** — quietly powerful; we don’t intimidate.
- **On your side** — an ally for the independent shop vs. the giants.
- **Honest** — we say what it does and doesn’t do; no jargon, no hype.

Voice & tone rules

- **Do:** short sentences. “Store Name,” “Order Status,” “Saved successfully.” Outcomes over features. Warm, direct, occasionally light. Always tell the user *what to do next*.
- **Don’t:** say `uuid`, `payload`, `multi-tenant`, “200 OK,” “leverage synergies,” or “enterprise-grade.” No status codes or stack traces in front of a shopkeeper.
- **Visual/verbal cues:** clean and confidence-building (not “agency-cool”), generous whitespace, real screenshots of *their* world (a storefront with cards/banners), legible type, calm trustworthy color. The product’s own UX rules (loading/empty/error states, plain-language feedback) *are* the brand — design and copy must match.

This is consistent top-to-bottom: a shopkeeper hits a marketing page that sounds like a helpful neighbor, then opens a product that *also* talks like one. Consistency across channels is what reads as “dependable.”

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5. How a positioning change ripples down (the whole point)

Suppose 12 months in you discover your fastest, highest-value buyers are **sign & large-format shops**, not general print shops. You change one positioning component — **best-fit customer** and **category** (“web-to-print for *sign and large-format* shops”). Watch it cascade:

- **Messaging:** Roof becomes “Your sign shop, online…”; Pillar 2 emphasizes large-format pricing (sq-ft/area rules) and proofing; pillar proof points swap to banner/signage examples.
- **Branding:** imagery shifts to banners and vehicle wraps; voice stays plainspoken but vocabulary moves to sign-shop terms (“substrate,” “grommets”) used the way *that* owner says them.
- **Everything downstream:** homepage hero, ad targeting, demo script, onboarding sample catalog, even default products in the seeder.

The lesson: because each layer derives from the one above, changing positioning is cheap to *decide* but expensive to *execute* — so make the positioning call deliberately, validate it with customers, and don't re-litigate the taglines until the position itself changes.

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6. Prioritized action checklist (this week / this month)

1. **This week — adopt the internal positioning statement** (§2.6) as your single source of truth. Print it; pin it. Every page must trace back to it.
2. **This week — interview 5 shop owners** (3 current/trial users, 2 lost prospects). Validate competitive alternatives and the "I'm not technical enough" fear. Capture verbatim phrases.
3. **Week 2 — build the messaging house** (§3): roof + 3 pillars + ≥2 proof points each. One page.
4. **Week 2 — write a one-page voice guide** (§4): 5 attributes, do/don't word lists, 3 before/after rewrites.
5. **Week 3 — rewrite the homepage** against the house: hero = roof, three sections = pillars, proof under each. Kill every feature-list paragraph that isn't a pillar.
6. **Week 3-4 — align the product's first-run** (onboarding copy, empty states, default catalog) to the same voice. Marketing and product must sound identical.
7. **Ongoing — replace founder-claims with real proof** (named testimonials, setup-time data, review-site presence) as customers land.

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7. Metrics / KPIs to track

Layer	What to measure	Signal
Positioning	"Does it pass the 5-second test?" — show the homepage to 5 shop owners; can they say what it is and who it's for?	≥4/5 correct = positioning lands
Messaging	Homepage hero → demo/signup conversion; which pillar drives clicks	Rising conversion; one pillar usually wins — lead with it
Brand	Branded search volume; "sounds like you" recognition; review sentiment ("easy to set up")	Mentions of *simple/easy* = brand promise believed
Cascade health	Sales-call language vs. site language drift	Reps inventing their own pitch = your house is failing

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8. Common mistakes / anti-patterns

- **Skipping positioning, polishing taglines.** Endless wordsmithing is a symptom of no underlying decision.

- **Pillars that are features, not outcomes.** “Fabric.js design studio” is a feature; “your customers design it themselves” is a pillar.
- **Competing on the incumbents’ axis.** Don’t win a feature-depth war against OnPrintShop/Infigo — that’s *their* category. Win on “a shop owner can run it alone.”
- **Enterprise voice to a non-enterprise buyer.** “Multi-tenant, scalable, enterprise-grade” actively scares your customer. Plainspoken beats sophisticated.
- **Marketing/product voice mismatch.** A friendly homepage that opens into a UI showing `uuid` and “System error” breaks the brand promise instantly.
- **Positioning by committee, changed weekly.** Decide deliberately, validate with customers, then hold it stable until the *position* (not the mood) genuinely changes.

Further reading / sources

- April Dunford, *Obviously Awesome* — framework overview: https://www.aprildunford.com/books
- April Dunford positioning framework guide (5 components, order to work them): https://www.kathirvel.com/guide-april-dunford-positioning-framework/
- 10-step positioning process summary (Heinz Marketing): https://www.heinzmarketing.com/blog/10-step-positioning-process-an-obviously-awesome-book-summary-part-3/
- Positioning vs. messaging vs. narrative (the cascade): https://jeffbenanto.medium.com/positioning-vs-messaging-vs-narrative-8f5147668cf7
- Positioning vs. messaging — the costly SaaS founder mistake (Forget The Funnel): https://forgetthefunnel.com/resources/ep-24-positioning-vs-messaging
- The B2B Messaging House framework (roof/pillars/foundation): https://barestrategy.com/blog/messaging-house-framework
- B2B messaging hierarchy — value prop → pillars → proof points: https://discover.gtmplaybook.co/messaging-hierarchy-framework
- Brand voice for small-business software (Mailchimp model; honest-vs-premium conversion lift): https://www.enji.co/blog/what-is-a-brand-voice-and-tone
- Brand tone of voice examples: https://iconicfox.com.au/brand-tone-of-voice-examples/
- Web-to-print storefronts vs. Vistaprint (sell online without a developer): https://www.printxpand.com/blog/vistaprint-clone/
- OnPrintShop / DesignNBuy reviews (incumbent setup-friction signal): https://www.softwaresuggest.com/onprintshop

Print-Flow-360 — Marketing & Demand Playbook

Source: readme/research/marketing/README.md

IN SHORT — KEY TAKEAWAYS

This document is a step-by-step marketing plan for Print-Flow-360. It explains how to find print shop owners who want to sell online, convince them to try the product, and turn them into paying customers — without spending like a big company. If you follow the plan, you will know exactly where to spend your time and money to get your first real customers.

The main parts explained simply:

- **Own the "web-to-print" category** — "Web-to-print" simply means "selling print products online." Instead of inventing a brand-new category (which costs millions), the plan is to loudly own the slice of that market for small, owner-run shops. The enemy is the belief that "you need a developer to sell print online." The promise is that a shop owner can set it all up themselves over a weekend.
- **Positioning and messaging** — Positioning means deciding in one sentence who the product is for and why it beats others. That decision must come first. Every page, email, and demo must then tell the same simple story: "run your online print shop yourself, no developer needed." Never lead with a feature list.
- **Two types of marketing: capture vs. generate** — At any moment, only about 5 in 100 print shop owners are actively searching for software. "Capture" means being easy to find when those 5 are looking (comparison pages, directory listings, Google searches). "Generate" means planting the idea in the other 95 who don't know this is possible yet (founder posts in print communities, workshops, direct outreach). You need both, but spend more time on capture first because it gives fast results.
- **Win one city at a time** — Instead of trying to reach every city at once, pick one area (20–60 shops), do personal outreach as the founder, and build word-of-mouth there before moving to the next. Also, make sure the product automatically helps shop owners appear in local Google searches (Google Maps, local business listings).
- **Get listed in software directories** — Sites like Capterra and G2 are where buyers go to compare software before they decide. Getting listed is free. Asking happy customers to leave a review (offering a small thank-you gift for writing one, not for saying nice things) builds trust fast.
- **Show the product working, don't just describe it** — Run a free, live online workshop every two weeks called something like "Sell print online in 45 minutes." Show people how easy it is, don't pitch. Also put a clickable demo on the homepage so anyone can try it without signing up.
- **Cold email done right** — Cold email means reaching out to shop owners who have never heard of the product. The key rule: treat it like an engineering problem, not a writing problem. Use a separate email address (not your main domain), set up the technical trust signals (SPF, DKIM, DMARC — these are email safety certificates), warm the account slowly for 2–3 weeks, and keep the list clean. Done wrong, emails land in spam. Done right, it reaches shop owners who would never find you otherwise.

What to do with this:

Start by rewriting the homepage to lead with the problem ("sell print online without hiring a developer"), not a feature list. Then spend the first month claiming free directory listings and building three

> comparison pages — this catches people already searching and gives you proof fast before you invest in longer-term channels.

Print-Flow-360 wins by becoming the undisputed **“web-to-print for non-technical, owner-run print shops”** — the simplest way for a local print shop to sell online without hiring a developer. The demand and the category word (“web-to-print”) already exist, so we don’t pay to *create* a category; we **own a segment loudly**, wrapping it in full category-design narrative (the enemy is the “online means hire a developer / surrender to Vistaprint” status quo; the promised land is a branded storefront the owner sets up themselves in a weekend). Because only ~5% of shops are in-market at any moment, we run two engines: **capture** the searching 5% (comparison pages, directories, BOFU SEO) while **generating** demand in the latent 95% (founder POV in print communities, local territory-by-territory outreach, teach-don’t-pitch webinars, isolated cold email). Every channel reinforces one story, and the product’s plain-language UX *is* the proof — the moment a non-technical owner hits a UUID or config wall, the whole pitch is exposed as a lie.

The 7 Deep-Dive Docs

Doc	What it answers	Most important takeaway
Category Design & Narrative	Create a new category, or own a segment?	**Own the segment, don't create a category.** Category creation needs $100M+ and 6–10 years; keep the word "web-to-print," modify it, and borrow category-design's *narrative weapons* (named enemy, old-vs-new, promised land) for 1% of the cost.
Positioning, Messaging & Branding	How do positioning → messaging → brand cascade?	Decide **positioning first** (the strategic "who/why-we-win"), then derive the messaging house (roof + 3 outcome pillars) and a plainspoken/reassuring brand voice. Win on "a shop owner can run it alone," never a feature-depth war.
Demand Gen vs. Capture	Catch existing demand, or create new demand?	Only **~5% are in-market**; run both engines, weight ~60–70% capture (fast proof) / ~25–30% generation (founder *time*, compounding moat). Trust "How did you hear about us?" over your analytics dashboard.
Local & Geo Marketing + SEO	How do we win location-bound buyers?	Acquire **one metro at a time** (founder-led outreach + associations) and **bake local-SEO into the product** (LocalBusiness schema, GBP sync, review automation). Sell "more local orders / get found on Google Maps," not features.
Marketplace & Directory Presence	Where do buyers build their shortlist?	Listing is **free** on Capterra/GetApp/Software Advice (one claim = 3 sites) + G2; run an **FTC-clean review engine** (~$25–50 gift card for the *act* of reviewing, never for sentiment). Stay standalone — don't make a Shopify app your core motion.
Webinars, Demos & Live Selling	How do we prove the product to intimidated buyers?	**Show, don't tell.** Run a recurring teach-don't-pitch workshop ("Sell online in 45 minutes"), put an always-on **interactive self-serve demo** on the homepage, and reserve 1:1 calls for hand-raisers framed as "let's set up *your* shop."
Cold Email & Deliverability	How do we reach owners who don't search?	Treat deliverability as **engineering, not copywriting.** Send from an **isolated** domain (never `printflow360.com`), authenticate SPF+DKIM+DMARC, warm 2–3 weeks, verify the list (<1% bounce), and keep spam complaints <0.1%.

How These Fit Together

The seven docs form one chain from strategy to execution:

- **WHY / WHAT — the foundation (Category + Positioning).** These two are upstream of everything. They decide *who we're for* (non-technical, owner-run local shops), *the enemy* (the "you need a developer / just use Vistaprint" status quo), and *the one story* every page, email, and demo must tell. Get these wrong and every channel below amplifies a muddled message.
- **THE STRATEGY — Demand Gen vs. Capture.** This is the bridge from positioning to channels. It tells us *how to split our limited time*: capture the 5% already searching (proves the business fast) while generating awareness in the 95% who don't yet know they can sell online without a developer. It assigns every channel below to a track.

- **THE HOW — the four channels.** Each executes one or both tracks:
  - **Local & Geo + Directories** are primarily **capture** (be found and win the shortlist at the moment of decision), with local territory density also seeding word-of-mouth.
  - **Webinars/Demos + Cold Email + founder community POV** are primarily **generation** (plant the realization in the latent 95%), with the self-serve demo and BOFU pages converting hand-raisers.

The throughline: **positioning decides the story → demand strategy decides where to spend founder time → channels deliver the story to the right track.** And the product's §0 UX bar is the connective tissue — "no developer needed" only holds if the first-run experience proves it.

90-Day Action Plan (highest-leverage move from each doc)

Days 1–30 — Foundation + capture the searching 5%

1. **Adopt the internal positioning statement** as the single source of truth and **rewrite the homepage hero** to lead with the enemy + promised land ("Sell print online without hiring a developer"), not features. *(Positioning, Category)*
2. **Add "How did you hear about us?"** to every demo/sign-up form — the single highest-leverage one-hour action for honest attribution. *(Demand Gen vs. Capture)*
3. **Ship 3 comparison/BOFU pages** (vs OnPrintShop, OnPrintShop-alternative-for-small-shops, Shopify-for-print-shops) and **claim Capterra (→ GetApp + Software Advice) + G2** profiles. *(Capture, Directories)*
4. **Pick metro #1** (20–60 independent shops, not Vistaprint-saturated) and start **founder-led outreach with a free Map Pack audit** as the door-opener. *(Local & Geo)*

Days 31–60 — Stand up the generation engines 5. **Run the flagship workshop live** ("Sell online in 45 minutes," teach-don't-pitch) every 2 weeks, and **build 3 Storylane interactive demos** ("See it in action — no signup") on the homepage. *(Webinars/Demos)* 6. **Build the cold-email infrastructure**: buy an isolated domain, set SPF/DKIM/DMARC, start 2–3 week warm-up, and verify a 500–1,000 print-shop list to <1% bounce. *(Cold Email)* 7. **Launch the FTC-clean review engine** — send the same small thank-you to all live customers who hit a success trigger; target 10 Capterra + 10 G2 reviews. *(Directories)* 8. **Ship LocalBusiness schema** auto-injection + the 9-step "Local Presence" onboarding checklist into the product. *(Local & Geo — product wedge)*

Days 61–90 — Compound and systematize 9. **Record the best workshop run → evergreen webinar** (auto-runs weekday 11am/2pm) so the best 45 minutes works 24/7. *(Webinars/Demos)* 10. **Launch the cold sequence** (4-step, personalized, Tue–Thu mornings) at 5–10/inbox/day, watching guardrail metrics daily. *(Cold Email)* 11. **Founder POV drumbeat**: 1 plain-language post/week in print Facebook groups + LinkedIn ("You don't need a developer to sell print online"), help-first, never pitch. *(Demand Gen)* 12. **Publish the POV manifesto** ("the web-to-print market forgot the shop owner") and get written into 3 neutral "best web-to-print" listicles. *(Category, Directories)*

North-Star & Leading-Indicator Metrics

Metric	Why it matters	Track
Time-to-first-online-order (per new shop)	The true North Star — proves the product works and the "no developer" promise holds	Leading
Self-serve activation rate (% who get a storefront live *without* support contact)	Validates the entire positioning; a high support rate means the UX contradicts the story	Leading
Branded search volume for "Print-Flow-360"	The clearest proxy that demand *generation* is working (people aren't searching the category yet)	Leading
% of sign-ups citing community/founder content in "How did you hear about us?"	The only honest read on generation; dashboards are blind to dark social	Leading
Demo-request / trial volume from BOFU pages + directories	Capture engine health; fast-moving, validates messaging and ICP	Lagging (fast)
Capterra + G2 review count & rating (≥4.5, steady recency)	Drives organic shortlist rank and trust at the moment of decision	Lagging
Trial → paid conversion rate	The ultimate business-works signal that every channel feeds	Lagging

Webinars, Demos & Live Selling for Print-Flow-360

Source: readme/research/marketing/WEBINARS_DEMOS_LIVE_SELLING_2026-06-16.md

IN SHORT — KEY TAKEAWAYS

This document explains the best way to show Print-Flow-360 to print shop owners so they feel confident enough to sign up. The big idea is simple: instead of asking people to fill out a “Request a Demo” form and wait for a sales call, let them see the product working immediately — no pressure, no login. That single shift is what separates you from every competitor.

The main parts explained simply:

- **Teach-don’t-pitch workshop** — A free 45-minute online session where you show shop owners how to take orders online, using your product as the live example. You build a real product and set real prices on screen while they watch. No hard sell. People who find it useful will ask to sign up on their own.
- **Self-serve interactive demo** — A clickable copy of your product that lives on your website, open to anyone, no signup needed. Visitors click through a few real screens and see how it works. This works 24/7 so you don’t have to be on a call for every curious visitor.
- **Three-layer funnel** — The workshop brings people in at the top (interest). The clickable demo lets them explore in the middle (consideration). A personal call at the bottom closes the people who are already ready to switch. Each layer does a different job.
- **1:1 demo — only for ready buyers** — Save personal calls for people who already watched the workshop and played with the demo. Frame the call as “let’s set up your shop,” not a product tour they’ve already seen.
- **Email reminder sequence** — When someone signs up for the workshop, send 4-5 reminder emails leading up to it. Research shows this alone can double the number of people who actually show up on the day.
- **Evergreen (always-running) webinar** — After you’ve run the workshop live a few times and refined it, record your best session and set it to play automatically every day. Your best 45-minute pitch then works around the clock with no extra effort.
- **Live video on LinkedIn/YouTube** — Stream your live builds to LinkedIn and YouTube so shop owners stumble across you while scrolling. Clip the best moments into short videos that spread on their own.
- **Mistakes to avoid** — Don’t pitch instead of teach. Don’t hide the product behind a form. Don’t skip the reminder emails. Don’t spend founder time on 1:1 calls with people the free demo should be handling.

What to do with this: Write the 45-minute workshop script this week and pick a date two weeks away. At the same time, build three short clickable demos using Storylane (free tier) and put a “See it in action — no signup” button on your homepage. These two things together are the whole strategy.

TL;DR: Your buyers are non-technical print shop owners who are intimidated by software and don’t read docs — so “show, don’t tell” is your single highest-leverage channel. Run a recurring free *workshop* (“Get your print shop selling online in 45 minutes") that teaches, doesn't pitch; put an always-on **interactive self-serve demo** on your homepage so curious owners can touch the product without booking anything; and reserve live 1:1 demos for hand-raisers who are ready to switch. This combination — group teach-webinars (top of funnel) → self-serve interactive demo (middle) → 1:1 demo (bottom) — is the cheapest, most founder-executable GTM motion you have right now.

> **Why this matters for Print-Flow-360** Your competitors (OnPrintShop, DesignNBuy, Pressero/Aleyant, Infigo) sell to print shops the same way enterprise software is sold: a "Request a Demo" form, a gated sales call, weeks of back-and-forth. That's a wall for a non-technical shop owner who just wants to see if this thing actually works. If you own the experience of *"see it working in 5 minutes, no developer, no sales pressure,"* you win the exact positioning you're chasing: **the simplest way for a local print shop to sell online.** Webinars and demos aren't just a channel here — they are the proof of the positioning.

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1. The core idea: "show, don't tell" beats "request a demo"

Your product is inherently visual and hands-on (storefront builder, live pricing, drag-and-drop design studio). A non-technical owner's #1 unspoken question is *"Will I be able to use this myself?"* No feature list answers that — only **seeing it work** does. This is the **product-led "show, don't tell"** principle, and the data backs it: B2B SaaS companies report PLG (product-led growth) motions convert qualified leads at ~25–30% with a 3–6 month payback, versus 12–18 months for traditional sales-led (Optifai). For a product under ~$10K annual contract value (which you are), PLG/self-serve is the recommended default; sales-led is reserved for larger deals (Salesmotion).

Your three-layer funnel:

Layer	Format	Job	Effort to run
Top — attract & educate	Live group workshop ("teach, don't pitch")	Build trust, generate registrations/email list	Medium (recurring)
Middle — let them touch	Interactive self-serve demo on your site	Convert visitors → qualified leads, 24/7, no human	One-time build
Bottom — close the switchers	Live 1:1 demo / migration call	Convert ready buyers, handle "will my catalog move over?"	High (founder time)

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2. Top of funnel: the "teach, don't pitch" workshop

The framework

The proven webinar structure for 2025 is **~20 minutes of framework/teaching + ~20 minutes live Q&A + a soft, value-driven close with no hard pitch** (Factors.ai). B2B buyers trust peer experience and education over sales pitches — so the workshop must deliver real value even to someone who never buys. The teaching itself becomes the demo.

Your flagship: *"Get Your Print Shop Selling Online in 45 Minutes"*

Not a Print-Flow-360 sales webinar — a **how-to workshop** that any shop owner benefits from, where your product happens to be the easiest way to do what you're teaching.

Outline / script:

1. **(0–5 min) Hook + promise.** "By the end of this, you'll know exactly what it takes to take orders online — and you'll see a real print shop storefront built live, start to finish." State who it's for ("independent shops, no developer, no tech background").
2. **(5–15 min) Teach the framework** (vendor-neutral, genuinely useful): the 4 things every online print storefront needs — (1) a product catalog with **live pricing** (vs. emailing quotes), (2) a way for customers to **design/personalize** without back-and-forth proofs, (3) **online ordering + payment**, (4) **order/job tracking** so nothing falls through. This is education they can use even with a competitor.
3. **(15–35 min) Build it live.** Screen-share Print-Flow-360. Create a business-card product, set up tier pricing, open the design studio, place a test order, watch the print job appear. *This is the show-don't-tell core.* Narrate as a shop owner would ("now I price my 250-card vs 500-card tiers — no spreadsheet").
4. **(35–45 min) Live Q&A.** Answer real questions ("Can I move my existing products?" "Do I need to know HTML?" "What about my local pickup customers?"). Q&A is where intimidated buyers get unblocked.
5. **(Close, ~2 min) Soft CTA.** "If you want this for your shop, grab a free trial / book a 1:1 setup call — link in chat. Either way, the slides and recording are coming to your inbox." No pressure.

Cadence: Run it **live every 2 weeks** initially (consistency > frequency; aim for the proven sweet spots: **Tuesday or Thursday**, which host 59% of webinars, late morning in your target time zone). Avoid July/August (summer drop-off) (Livestorm).

Then make it evergreen

Live attendance drives the best leads (89% of webinar leads come from live attendees), but **on-demand replays generate ~2.4× the unique viewers** of the live session over a rolling 30 days, ~71% of replay watch time happens in the first 14 days, and replay leads convert only ~9% worse than live (Livestorm benchmark). So: run live for 4–6 sessions to refine the script, then **record your best run and turn it into an evergreen/automated webinar** that runs on a schedule (e.g. every weekday at 11am and 2pm). Now your best 45 minutes works 24/7 with zero founder time.

Variations once the flagship works

- **Topic workshops** (narrower, BOFU-flavored): "Pricing business cards & flyers without losing money," "Letting customers design their own banners (and skipping proof emails)."
- **Monthly open "office hours"** — a recurring live drop-in where any shop owner (customer or not) can ask anything. Low-prep, community-building, and a magnet for word-of-mouth in the tight-knit print community.

3. Middle of funnel: the always-on interactive self-serve demo

This is the **highest-ROI one-time build** in this whole plan, and where you most differentiate from competitors who hide behind “Request a Demo” forms.

An **interactive demo** is a guided, clickable replica of your product (captured from real screens) embedded on your website — the visitor clicks through a real flow with tooltips, no signup, no sales rep. Tools capture your actual UI via a browser extension and you’re live in hours (Storylane).

Tool recommendation for an early-stage founder:

Tool	Best for	Note
Storylane	Your pick. Transparent pricing (~$40/user/mo), AI-assisted creation, free tier (1 demo, unlimited views), cross-team use (Storylane)	Start here
Navattic	Top-of-funnel marketing demos, full HTML cloning	Strong alternative
Arcade	Fast, polished, AI-produced demos	Great for short embeds
Walnut / Reprise	Enterprise sales-team demos ($9,200+/yr, no free tier) (Storylane)	**Skip** — overkill/overpriced for you

What to build (3 short demos, ~5–8 clicks each):

1. **“Build a product & set live pricing”** — the catalog + pricing engine.
2. **“Let a customer design their own flyer”** — the Fabric.js design studio (your most visual, most differentiating screen).
3. **“From order to print job”** — the order → job lifecycle, so owners see nothing falls through.

Placement (UX-first, per your house rules): A “**See it in action — no signup**” button on the homepage hero and pricing page. Reserve layout space and show it inline; never a dead “Request demo” form. Gate the *third* click or the “see the rest” step behind an email capture — that’s your qualified-lead handoff. This turns anonymous traffic into leads 24/7 without you on a call.

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4. Bottom of funnel: 1:1 vs group demos

Use group demos (the workshop above) as your default top/middle. They scale your time and let prospects learn from each other’s questions.

Reserve live 1:1 demos for hand-raisers — someone who attended a workshop, played with the self-serve demo, and clicked “talk to us.” For these, the 1:1 isn’t a generic product tour (the demo already did that) — it’s a **“let’s set up *your* shop” call**: “Bring your top 5 products and I’ll show you exactly how they’d look and price in Print-Flow-360.” This reframes the sales call as *migration help*, which directly attacks the #1 switching objection for a non-technical owner (“moving is too hard”). For async hand-raisers who can’t book a time, send a personalized **Loom** walkthrough of their would-be storefront (Chameleon).

Rule of thumb: below ~$10K ACV, never gate the *first* look behind a 1:1 demo — that's why self-serve exists. Spend founder 1:1 time only on people the funnel has already warmed.

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5. Live selling / live commerce — a *parallel* play (and a content engine)

Live commerce (selling via live video, big in retail) isn't your core channel — you sell software, not flyers. But it's relevant two ways:

- **As a feature story for your shops:** their end-customers increasingly expect modern buying experiences; "your online store, open 24/7" is the live-commerce-adjacent value prop you market.
- **As your own awareness tactic:** go **live on YouTube and LinkedIn** with the workshop and "build a print store live" sessions. Live video on LinkedIn surfaces you to the small-business/owner audience cheaply. Repurpose every live build into short clips (the design studio in action is naturally shareable). Tools: **StreamYard** (best fit for most teams, streams to LinkedIn/YouTube/Facebook simultaneously) for the broadcast layer; **Demio** ($45–80/mo, evergreen + marketing-workflow focus) or **Livestorm** (pay-per-attendee credits, CRM sync) for the registration/gated-webinar layer (StreamYard, StackScored).

Recommendation: Start with **Demio** (registration + evergreen automation + email built in, cheapest path to the full funnel) and add **StreamYard** only when you want simulcast to LinkedIn/YouTube.

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6. The webinar funnel & email sequence (this is where most of the result lives)

Filling seats and getting people to actually show up is 80% of webinar success. Benchmarks: average registration-to-attendance lands around **48–57%** (median live-attend ~42%) (Livestorm, ON24/MarketingProfs). **Reminder sequences can lift attendance by up to 73%**, and a 3-touch reminder cadence pushed registrant→attendee from 56% to 71% in one study (Univid, EasyWebinar).

The sequence (send 3–5 emails; segment registrants from non-registrants):

Timing	Email	Purpose
On signup	Confirmation	Add to calendar, set expectation
7 days before	Reminder #1	Reinforce value, “here’s what you’ll build”
3 days before	Reminder #2	Urgency + handle objections (“no tech skills needed”)
24 hours before	Reminder #3	Login link, technical details
~1 hour before	“We’re starting soon”	Final nudge (often the highest-impact touch)
After (attendees)	Thank-you + recording + soft CTA	Convert
After (no-shows)	“Sorry we missed you — here’s the replay”	Recover the ~50% who didn’t attend

Deliverability matters or none of this lands. Since the 2024 Google/Yahoo sender requirements, authenticate your sending domain with **SPF, DKIM, and DMARC**, keep spam complaints **under 0.3%** (ideally <0.1%), and include one-click unsubscribe. Misconfigure this and your reminder sequence — the thing that makes webinars work — silently goes to spam.

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7. Prioritized action checklist (do in this order)

1. **This week:** Write the 45-minute workshop script (§2). Pick a date 2 weeks out, Tuesday or Thursday late-morning.
2. **This week:** Set up **Demio** (or Zoom Webinar to start free-ish) + a landing page + the 5-email reminder sequence. Verify SPF/DKIM/DMARC.
3. **Weeks 1–6:** Run the workshop live every 2 weeks. Refine the script from real Q&A questions.
4. **Week 2:** Build **3 Storylane interactive demos** (catalog/pricing, design studio, order→job) and put “See it in action — no signup” on your homepage hero. Gate the 3rd step on email.
5. **Week 6:** Record your best live run → publish as an **evergreen webinar** (weekday 11am/2pm auto-runs).
6. **Ongoing:** Reserve 1:1 calls for hand-raisers only; frame them as “let’s set up *your* shop.” Start a monthly **office hours**.
7. **Month 2+:** Simulcast live builds to LinkedIn/YouTube via StreamYard; chop into clips.

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8. Metrics & KPIs to track

Funnel stage	Metric	Target (benchmark-based)
Promotion	Registrations per workshop	Trend up; ~60+ is a healthy session
Show-up	Registration → attendance	**≥50%** (lift with the 5-email sequence)
Engagement	Avg. watch time	~24+ min of a 45-min session
Self-serve demo	Demo starts → email captured	Track conversion; this is your 24/7 lead engine
Conversion	Attendee/demo-user → trial signup	Watch the rate; live attendees convert best
Conversion	Trial → paid	Your true north metric
Replay	Replay views vs live	Expect replays to ~2.4× live viewers
1:1	Hand-raiser demo → close rate	Should be high (pre-qualified)

9. Common mistakes & anti-patterns to avoid

- **Pitching instead of teaching.** If the workshop is a 45-min ad, attendance and trust collapse. Deliver real value to non-buyers.
- **Hiding the product behind a "Request a Demo" form** (the incumbent default). For a non-technical, intimidated buyer this is a wall. Self-serve interactive demo first.
- **Skipping the reminder sequence.** One invite = ~half the attendance you'd otherwise get. The reminders *are* the strategy.
- **Going evergreen too early.** Run live first so the script is battle-tested by real Q&A before you automate it.
- **Buying enterprise demo tools (Walnut/Reprise) at $9K+/yr** when Storylane's free/cheap tier does the job at your stage.
- **Demoing like an engineer.** Narrate as a shop owner ("now I set my 500-card price"), never expose UUIDs, internal terms, or "let me just configure the payload." Same plain-language standard as the product itself.
- **Ignoring email deliverability.** No SPF/DKIM/DMARC = your funnel quietly lands in spam and you'll blame the channel.
- **Over-investing founder hours in 1:1 demos** for unqualified curiosity the self-serve demo should be handling for free.

Further reading / sources

- Livestorm — Webinar Benchmark Report: https://livestorm.co/webinar-report-benchmark

- ON24 — 2025 Webinar Benchmarks: https://www.on24.com/blog/key-takeaways-from-the-2025-webinar-benchmarks-report/
- MarketingProfs — B2B Webinar Benchmarks: https://www.marketingprofs.com/charts/2025/52917/b2b-webinar-benchmarks-conversion-attendance-personalization
- EasyWebinar — Webinar Email Automation Sequence: https://easywebinar.com/blog/webinar-email-automation-sequence-streamline-your-webinar-funnel/
- Univid — Webinar Invitation Emails / attendance lift: https://univid.io/blog/webinar-invitation-emails/
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